

A woman with long dark hair, wearing a dark trench coat, is the central figure. She is looking down and slightly to the side. The background is a dark, smoky blue.

THE *SCORCHING* EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY

A
KILLER
OF A
ONE NIGHT STAND

EPISODE TWO

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR

MAX SEBASTIAN



THE *SCORCHING* EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY

A
KILLER
OF A
ONE NIGHT STAND

EPISODE TWO

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR

MAX SEBASTIAN



THE *SCORCHING* EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY

A
KILLER
OF A
ONE NIGHT STAND

EPISODE TWO

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR
MAX SEBASTIAN

About the Author

Max Sebastian has written more than 20 novels, and regularly tops the bestseller lists for steamy erotic fiction. He began writing erotica at Literotica.com nearly two decades ago, and broke into the wider world of publishing in 2011.

Since then, Max has become well-known for sensual, steamy adventures in which couples explore thrilling alternatives to monogamous relationships, on their way to a very raunchy happy ever after—including menage stories, wife-sharing, hotwives, cuckolding and partner-swapping in various forms.

Max lives in London, England, and loves to hear from readers. Visit his website at www.maxsebastian.net.

Some of Max's Other Books

Web: MaxSebastian.net

[Anarchy of the Heart](#)

[Submitting to Her](#)

[The Madeleine Trilogy](#)

[What's Mine Is Yours](#)

[What's Yours Is Mine](#)

[The Game](#)

[She's a Star](#)

[Heidi, Corrupted](#)

[His Week With My Wife](#)

[Out of His League \(with Kenny Wright\)](#)

[Rock Her World](#)

[The One That I Married](#)

[Game Changer](#)

[Obsessive Trilogy](#)

[Marriage 2.0](#)

[A Lockdown Affair](#)

A Killer of a One Night Stand

Episode Two

Max Sebastian

MAXSEBASTIAN.NET

Copyright © 2014 by Max Sebastian All rights reserved.

Cover Image © shmeljov | bigstockphoto.com

Second Edition published July 2021

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means, including information storage and retrieval systems, without written permission from the author, except for the use of brief quotations in a book review.

Contents

[Prologue](#)

[Chapter 1](#)

[Chapter 2](#)

[Chapter 3](#)

[Chapter 4](#)

[Chapter 5](#)

[Chapter 6](#)

[Chapter 7](#)

[Chapter 8](#)

[Chapter 9](#)

Prologue

“S o wait, there’ve been four Hotel Killings? I thought there were just two.”

“Four. The police don’t think they’re all linked, but they’re beginning to see it.

The media seems to accept the idea.”

“The newspapers seem to want as many deaths as possible.”

“They’re just selling papers. Stirring up the emotions to get people to pick up a copy.”

“So how can you be so sure she killed—twice—before Nate.”

She kissed him, making it difficult for him to concentrate on the darker things.

Her soft lips tasted of sweet almonds, and though it was getting very late, there was no way he was going to stop her.

He coursed his fingers through her silky bell of blonde hair, while his other hand swept over the luxurious red satin of her baby-doll, and then over the matching panties clinging to her shapely rear.

“The first one was a year ago,” he said in between kisses, “and I think because he was strangled, at least from what I read, the police think it’s a different crime entirely.”

“And that was someone like your brother, he worked in the City?”

He shook his head. “A journalist. Julian Foster. It looks like I might get to meet his wife sometime soon, to find out more about him.”

“Because he was a journalist, that was another reason the police think his murder is unconnected?”

“I assume so.”

She held his face in her hands as she kissed him, her sapphire eyes flickering over his, reading him, impressed by him. Jonah felt a little burst of warmth inside his chest—no girl had ever really looked at him in that way before.

“The second victim was Lord Moss, Lord Douglas Moss,” he said, continuing merely as a way to keep talking to this exquisite creature. To give himself time to fully recover from his alcohol-fueled evening.

“Oh I remember that, last year, wasn’t it? It was all over the news. I thought it was some nut-job bell-hop who tried to rob him.”

He shook his head gently. “There were a load of theories at the time, but the police never released details of what happened.”

“And you think it was the same as what happened to your brother?”

“I think it’s likely. And because he’s a member of the House of Lords, it’s all tied up with the Official Secrets Act.”

Pressing herself against his hardness without taking him inside her, Emma moaned quietly, making her need so very clear. Had she really been waiting for him, all the time he’d been out with Lina that evening? As soon as he’d been done, his blonde companion had come right over.

He loved feeling her hair pouring all over his face, breathing in her characteristic coconut scent. Touching his lips to hers, so soft, so warm, so sweet.

“It’s a nice big bed.”

“Isn’t it?”

“Your standards of hotel room have definitely risen.”

“I figured my Robert character works in the City, so he’d want to treat his dates to a little luxury.”

The room was impressive. But right now, Jonah had eyes only for the beautiful blonde lying with him in the middle of that enormous mattress. He brushed her hair back behind her ear and craned his neck slightly to kiss her velvet neck, gaining a surge of her fragrance by reward.

“So your brother... he was the third one, you think?” She spoke quietly, with sympathy.

“Uh-huh,” he said. “The police always thought I was just trying to make his death seem like a bigger deal than it was. Third victim of a serial killer, rather than just the poor beggar who had a fatal argument with his date.”

“And then the fourth one happened.”

“Martin Sallow. He worked in the City, like Nate.”

“Do you really think the killer is targeting boys from the City?”

He shrugged. “You know how Lord Moss made his fortune? In the City. He ran a big equity fund.”

She sat up on him, riding his hardness without removing her underwear, stirring her hips as she rubbed her heat over his shaft, enjoying how hard she was making him before she even allowed him within her tightness. She smiled as he reached up to cup one of her small but pert breasts through the red satin, and pushed out her chest for him.

“So when does all this stop?” she asked. “You know, the online dating. Meeting random women, hoping one of them is the killer?”

He shrugged, “Guess I don’t really have an exit strategy. But I’ve got to do something. Maybe if I get it right, I can draw her out.”

She smiled, as though to tell him without words that he was crazy, but that she liked it. She leaned forward to kiss his mouth, pressing her breasts against his body, then rose to allow him to kiss his way down her chest, to push down the satin and reveal her stiff little nipples only to envelop them in his hot mouth.

“Oh God...” she moaned, but then took a breath and calmly asked him: “I was your first, right? Your first date from the website your brother was

using.”

“You were.”

“And I’ve been the best of them?”

“Of course.”

Sharing a mischievous smile at that, as Emma now kissed her way down his chest, his stomach, sliding her way down his body to lie between his legs, before gently stroking her nose up the length of his hard cock.

“You’ve only had a few dates so far, though, right?” she asked, her fingers curling around his manhood, her eyes flicking up to his before she began licking him around the base of his cock.

“I haven’t been doing it too long.”

As she eventually reached his tip, she slipped it inside her mouth briefly, for little more than an extended kiss.

“The redhead nurse—”

“Becky.”

“The mysterious blonde dominatrix...”

“Jessica.”

“And now Lina. She must have been good, huh. Since I found her.” She sank down on his shaft, filling her mouth with his hardness, squeezing the rest of his column tight in her hand.

“She was good,” he said, brushing her hair out of her face. “I don’t think she was married, though. I guess she thought I was.”

Emma smacked her lips as she withdrew his shiny cock from her mouth. “And you are definitely certain the killer was a married woman?”

Jonah shrugged. “Everything I’ve heard makes me think that way. And with hindsight, that conversation I had with Nate just before he went out that night...”

I don't know... perhaps some of the things he was holding back from me was because he was going out to meet a married woman."

Emma lapped gently at his tip, crushing his shaft in her fingers. "I can still smell her on you, you know," she said with a wicked grin. "Even though you went

against my wishes and took a shower afterwards."

Jonah felt his cock throb at the idea of Emma enjoying the fact that he'd just been with another woman. She was so naughty, so wild.

"I guess she did come... rather a lot," he smiled.

"You made her come rather a lot. This big prick of yours."

Then she was devouring him, and for a few moments he just had to ride it out, try not to let the incredible sensations overcome him, push him over the edge.

At last, he urged her up so that while she knelt in front of him, he could remove her baby doll—and, with a little jink of her hips, her panties. Naked, she turned her back on him, allowing him to hold her, embrace her, touch her sweet breasts and press his face into her hair, breathing in her clean scent.

"Are you seeing any of your dates again? Other than me, of course?"

She broke out of his grip, leaned forward, dropped onto her hands and knees, arching her back to push her cute butt up for him.

"I'm not sure," he said. "I don't really know if Nate saw any of his online dates a second time."

He ducked down, pulling her thighs back a little, out a little, so that he could edge his mouth between them and over the glistening folds of Emma's succulent pussy. He loved how she let out a little gasp of surprise, not expecting him to go down on her in such a position.

"This what you did with Lina?" she asked, breathing heavily, enjoying his mouth on her sensitive sex.

“Something like this,” he said, holding onto her hips firmly, forcing himself hard against her.

She couldn’t stand it for long, though—she needed him to fill her.

She giggled as he slid his big, rock-hard cock deep inside her tight channel. “I’ve never been fucked staring at a World Heritage Site before.”

It was a pretty spectacular view, looking out of the window onto the magnificent sight of Big Ben and Parliament in all their illuminated nocturnal glory. It drew the attention away from even the luxurious fittings of the room, the big bed with its chocolate leather headboard, the massive TV, the black glass-fronted wardrobe and the mood lighting that made the room look faintly like a science fiction movie set.

“Lina said something similar, too.”

That comment got him a playful glare over her shoulder, but she wasn’t jealous.

She couldn’t be: she was helping him manage his online dating profile, helping him correspond with potential dates through the No Strings website.

“You like having me as your new personal assistant?” she asked him, her glare turning into a mischievous grin.

“You won’t be filing sexual harassment complaints against me?” he joked, ramming his cock hard into her as though to test her harassment policy.

“Only if you stop doing this regularly,” she replied. “Boss.”

One

This one had given her name as Gabriella, and she had booked the hotel room.

He wasn’t complaining—the Savoy wasn’t exactly in his price range. But good for her if she fancied a little style. It seemed to fit with what Jonah was looking for, too: If Martin Sallow had been slain in the Hilton on

Park Lane, then why wouldn't it follow that the killer liked a luxury hotel?

You couldn't get much better than London's infamous Savoy, sitting on the Victoria Embankment looking over the Thames.

In their brief exchange through the No Strings website messaging system, Jonah had learned that Gabriella was 30, that she did something in the financial sector for a job, though she'd left out the specifics, and that she liked confident alpha males, particularly those in the City.

Jonah had tried to tease out a few more details, but he didn't want to scare her off—particularly since she had been the one to come to him first on No Strings to ask if he was up for a one night stand. She liked alpha males, but did that mean she was submissive, or did it mean she liked attempting to dominate alpha males?

Well, just because Martin Sallow had shown signs of being dominated during his final night with a woman, didn't mean the killer had to be that way with all men.

Gabriella hadn't been willing to reveal her marital status in their exchanges, but the fact that she had wanted to meet him at the hotel room, late in the evening with no dating preamble, no dinner, no movie, no drinks at a bar, no nervous conversation to see if they had chemistry—made him think she was probably married, wanting to do something quick and in secret.

He'd been impressed by the style of the hotel, but on his way up he'd been thinking that if she wanted something highly secret, there were probably hotels that were a little more subtle than this one.

He felt nervous, as he assumed he always would be with these dates. Turning up to meet a stranger for sex was one thing, but knowing there was a small chance she might be a killer was off the scale.

The room was up on the fourth floor, river side, so Gabriella was certainly splashing out for her little tryst.

When she opened the door promptly following his knock, he was a little taken aback to find her standing there in nothing but expensive-looking lingerie.

“Robert, right?”

“Uh... yeah, that’s it.”

“Come inside.”

She had an accent and a body to die for. She was pretty with dark hair, large very dark eyes and beautiful smooth golden skin, her complexion along with her accent suggesting a Mediterranean heritage—probably Spanish.

She was wearing a marine blue corset that held her petite frame tightly, extending suspenders down to hold up her black stockings, which matched her black panties. A petite woman, she was given height by a pair of black high-heeled stilettos, but it wasn’t these alone that gave her such refined poise. She was a cut above, it would seem. Everything about her exuded class.

The air in the room was laden with her perfume, a rich sweetness that went with her exotic nature.

“You look nice,” she said, leading him back into the large suite.

“You too,” he said, taking in her curves and that cute butt as he followed her.

“You look pretty incredible, actually.”

It was strange, of course, to come into this grand hotel room for the purpose only of sleeping with the stranger staying here. He felt almost as though he was some kind of discount escort or gigolo. Briefly exchanging pieces of paper now, disclosing their recent testing for medical issues, almost felt like taking care of the payment. Gabriella never lost her air of elegance and dignity, however. She’d done this before.

After what had happened with the blonde Jessica in that car park, he had to assume that plenty of these No Strings encounters could turn out to be unconventional. It was, after all, people who just wanted quick no-commitment sex, and often married people at that.

Gabriella perched on an ottoman that stood in front of a couch that looked a little more ostentatious than it probably was, and from somewhere, she

fished out a black satin blindfold—an eye mask, really, like something you might get given by an airline in first class.

“I’m all yours,” she said, putting on the mask, and it came as something of a disappointment to Jonah, although his manhood was certainly happy about the prospect of enjoying this beautiful woman.

But who was to say that the serial killer was definitely a dominant woman like Jessica?

She sat there expectantly, and even licked her lips in preparation for what she assumed was coming. Jonah felt more than a little awkward.

He paused a moment, then remembered that he wasn’t supposed to be portraying the quiet, mild-mannered academic that he was—he was supposed to be Robert, a City trader and an alpha-male. He wasn’t going to draw out a killer who preyed on such men unless he was fully believable in the role.

He unzipped his fly, and saw the pretty Spanish woman smile broadly knowing what he was doing.

He had to forget himself and be the City boy his website profile proclaimed him to be. Maybe Nate had been this kind of guy, maybe the married women who had wanted to be with him had wanted him to dominate them.

It didn’t hold that his murder had to be in exactly the same style as the fourth victim’s.

God, was he really doing this? Pulling his cock out, stroking himself a few times to reach full hardness, telling her:

“Open your mouth, Gabriella.”

She did as he asked, and he stepped up to her, placing a hand gently on the back of her head, feeling her silky hair briefly before he eased her toward him, his other hand holding up his stiff cock to her perfectly painted lips.

She was smiling as he touched the purple head to her lips, then her tongue emerged to lick over his tip, tracing out its shape. He could tell she was

pleased with his size even before she stretched her lips around it and engulfed him in the heat of her mouth.

“You like that?”

“Uh-huh,” she said meekly as she sucked on him, sinking down on his shaft.

He stroked her soft black hair as she began a rhythm on his length, holding the base of his cock with one hand, but getting a surprising amount of him inside her mouth.

She moaned quietly, enjoying her playing with strange cock.

Jonah removed her blindfold, it was too distracting, and he wanted to see her face. She looked up at him, smiling, seemingly adoring him, though it was no doubt part of her submissive act. She didn’t object to the removal of the mask—

seemed to accept that if he was in control here, it was his choice.

She was good with her mouth, knew how to make a man feel good with it.

It wasn’t long before he had to tell her to stop, however. There was such a thing as being too good at something, and he now wanted more from Gabriella than just her mouth.

“Should we find the bed?” he asked her.

She withdrew him from her mouth, though continued to pump him, looking up at him with doe eyes, “The bed would be wonderful.”

He urged her up to her feet, holding her hair, not really meaning to pull it, though on the first hint that he might, she smiled and appeared to want him to direct her like that.

God, were there men for whom this was just the natural way they were? It

wasn’t Jonah. He had to play the role, though. He playfully slapped her behind, which only drew out a sensual groan from the beautiful Spanish

woman, who now bit her lip with clear desire. He had to go with it, had to try to be Robert, not Jonah.

This time, he led her by the hand through to the bedroom.

Inside, he held her and shoved her up against a wall, holding her by the neck as he kissed her forcefully. She moaned, her fingers encircling his hard cock, and her breathing deepened as he released his grip on her, to kiss his way down to her cleavage, where he released her breasts from her corset. It wasn't the most restrictive of corsets.

"Are you married, Gabriella?" he asked her, putting his face up against hers and directing her a stern, don't-mess-with-me look.

She'd studiously avoided revealing it when they were conversing on the No Strings messaging platform, but Jonah felt now that she was giving him such control that he might be able to force it out of her.

He was right.

"Not tonight," she said.

Still avoiding the question. Did she mean she was married, but was taking the night off, or that she was single, and he shouldn't be asking? It was difficult to interpret her reply because of her accent, the inflection in her voice a touch too foreign to expose her.

Nate had gone for married women, Graham had said. His use of the No Strings website, rather than any other online dating or sex personals website, seemed to back up that idea, too. But did that mean he hadn't seen single women at all?

Almost slipping into sexual autopilot as he thought about the case briefly, he dropped a hand to her waist, and then to between her legs.

She was so wet. Her panties were saturated.

"You wish I was married?" she asked quietly.

He stirred his fingers against her sex through the dripping satin of her underwear.

“Normally I would prefer it,” he ventured, sensing that she most likely was married.

“Some men want you to be single, some men want you to be married.”

“I guess so.”

“But I’m the same either way.”

He pulled her over to the bed. There were things on the bedside table—
toys.

Sexual paraphernalia. Jonah wasn’t entirely confident he knew what they all were, or what they were supposed to do. Was he out of his depth again?

“So you tell men what they want to hear?” he asked, and she shrugged as if to say of course. The website is not about revealing who you really are. “You prefer single guys, or married men?”

She sat on the corner of the mattress, on the perfect white bedsheets, and glanced up at him with uncertainty in her eyes. He guessed that most men she was with did not ask about other men she dated.

“I prefer that they know what they’re doing,” she smiled, waiting patiently for his next move. “And that they have nice big cocks.”

He felt obligated to take his pick from the toys, to at least use something on her.

He picked up a pair of scarlet leather handcuffs—well, at least he could understand what they were for.

Gabriella’s fresh smile affirmed that he’d been right to try something from her bedside table. She turned on the edge of the bed, to present him with her hands behind her back.

He sat beside her, fastening the cuffs around her wrists.

Could the murderer—the Black Widow, as some of the tabloids were now calling her—be a single woman out for sex with married men? Would there be any reason for such a woman to kill those men?

Marital infidelity offered such a good motive for murder, but he couldn't be blinded to that as an easy answer. Serial killers didn't need motive, after all.

Perhaps an abusive childhood or something amiss with their genes, but not necessarily a logical reason to kill.

He had already started to assume Gabriella wasn't the killer, of course, from her submissive desires.

He thought she was starting to get suspicious about his questions, so he distracted her by standing up in front of her, putting his hand behind her head again, directing her gently but firmly to kneel in front of him and his exposed cock.

She was only too pleased to take him back inside her mouth, to forget about everything else.

He unfastened his belt, and pulled down his pants, held her head firmly, and now controlled her motion on his length. She enjoyed him fucking her face, her submissive nature appreciating him using her.

He could smell her arousal, though, through the cloak of her sweet perfume, and it drove him to urge her up, back onto the bed, her thighs spread open for him.

He leaned over her, gently kissed her soft mouth for the first time, tasting the hint of saltiness that came from her pleasuring him. He knelt on the floor before her, pulling aside her panties with the kind of force that might assure her of his continuing dominance. She was so wet, her little dark flower so beautiful framed by her stockings and the blue of her corset. Her scent was thick in the air.

Dominant guys could still appreciate the taste of a woman, couldn't they?

But they were right beside that table full of toys, and it made him feel obligated to take his pick once again. Again, he seized on the first thing he saw that he recognized and understood.

A big, black vibrator.

It was a quiet one, an expensive one, humming softly as he switched it on and brought it to her body. She let out a soft gasp as its tip touched her sensitive folds, and closed her eyes, moaning and sucking in breath as he pressed the thing

against her clit, gently stroked it along her slippery groove.

“If you were married, would you be angry if your husband did this kind of thing?” he asked her. It suddenly seemed absurdly as though he was torturing her, using instruments of oppression to extract valuable information.

“Oh... my God...” she whimpered, then looked up at him as though thinking she’d imagined his question.

“With other women I mean,” he said. “If you knew he was having these kind of affairs.”

She sucked in her breath, her strained expression indicating that his attention with the vibrator was overwhelming her senses to the point where it was hard for her to think of an answer to a proper question.

Jonah paused, lifted the thing from her pussy.

“Sure, I’d be angry.”

It was as though the threat of stopping forced an answer out of her.

Jonah put the humming black plastic phallus back to her glistening pussy, eliciting a few little cries that suggested the reward for her answer was appreciated.

“Why would you be angry? I mean, you sleep with married men.”

“I should be enough for him,” she said. “This... is different.”

Whimpering, gasping, she tilted her head back, her body shuddering in response to the throbbing column pressing against her sensitive flower, her hips bucking, making it difficult to keep the thing in position. She opened her legs as wide as possible to stabilize herself given that her hands were bound together underneath her body.

“Oh God... oh God...”

He didn't care what other dominant men did, he wanted what he wanted. He dropped the vibrator back on the bedside table and reached forward to peel those

little soaking black panties off her body, then drag her butt back to the edge of the mattress where he could get at her.

She didn't seem to object, but then the forceful manner in which he pulled off her underwear, and manhandled her so he could savor that sweet, hairless pussy, simply made him seem like an alpha male with a real taste for a woman.

“Oh my God... Oh Jesus...”

She tasted divine—subtle, smoky, somehow classy, yet with that characteristic zing of feminine desire.

“Oh yes... oh, please...”

She was looking down at him with something akin to astonishment as he lapped up her slick juices, flicking the tip of his tongue delicately over her clit. Made him think that her husband, wherever he was, did not tend to give her this kind of pleasure.

Those cries of hers were getting increasingly strained and high-pitched as she struggled for breath, her mouth open, her brow wrinkled by cute little dimples.

“Oh yeah... right there...”

The way she was shaking under him, her thighs quivering almost uncontrollably, made Jonah think again about Emma's advice to him on their first date, that a City trader like his alter ego, Robert would not do this for a woman. He would only ever take what he wanted, putting his own needs above and beyond any need to make her feel good.

Jonah was taking what he wanted—what he wanted was this beautiful woman, and any woman who gave him the honor of sharing intimate moments with him like this, to feel sensational. Only, someone like Robert would have different wants.

Sensing that she was building up to a powerful orgasm, then, Jonah slowed and stopped, drawing a momentary look of horror from Gabriella as she realized he was not going to give her release.

He stood, removing his clothes, his eyes holding her still like some kind of erotic

statue.

Then he moved over her, holding her, maneuvering her into the position he wanted so that he could take her.

“You want this, don’t you?”

“Yes, sir,” she said, and kneeling between her legs, he tapped the end of his big hard cock against the bright red lips of her soaking pussy.

“Ask me for it.”

“Please sir, will you give me your big, beautiful cock?”

He smiled, it could be fun playing a role that was nothing like you.

“Please... oh, please... fuck me...”

He tilted his manhood down, and eased forward, drawing out more blasphemies from his Spanish tigress as his tip slipped within her hot lips, and then up inside her, filling her.

“Oh God...”

He was no actor, but thinking about how he should be playing this dominant character actually helped him sustain his performance, keeping him from getting overly worked up and shooting down the one-way street that was the male climax.

Maybe he should have done more research about how dominant males made love.

She didn’t complain, though, as he urged her up, stripped her of her clothes other than those sexy black stockings, planting playful yet loud slaps on her behind as he told her to get on her hands and knees for him.

She had a peach of a behind, but it went alarmingly red where his hand struck her. Had he hurt her? But she was moaning with an unmistakable sexual response to it, even if he had. Unlike the rest of her body, she had strong tan lines in the shape of bikini bottoms, the pale skin of her shapely derriere perhaps

made the reddening of her flesh seem more disturbing that it was.

Feeling unable to ask her whether she was okay, he simply moved in on her, parted her legs, and directed his hardness between her glowing cheeks.

“Oh my God...”

She was wetter than ever, which reassured him to some extent as he split her cheeks and slid deep inside her again. She was responding to his force, which only encouraged him to fuck her harder and harder.

“Pull my hair...”

At first, he thought he didn’t hear her right.

“Pull my fucking hair...”

She said it quietly, as though in fear of reprisal for deeming to tell him what to do, though needing to make her needs known, or grant him approval for an act that seemed wholly wrong to Jonah.

He leaned forward, reached for her head, placed his fingers in her silky, heavy black hair, at first reluctant to actually go as far as he thought she wanted.

“Pull it...” she hissed.

He did as she asked, grabbing as much of her hair as possible under the impression that it would hurt her less, he held her head up with it as he continued slamming into her from behind.

She was so sexy, the way she jinked her hips as he fucked her, the fluid, lithe movement of her body.

Did she come? He wasn't even sure. Did she feel she was allowed to? The power of his thrusting into her, the impacts of his body against hers, he wondered if any climax she had was simply hidden.

At the end, she lay on her back under him and begged him to come all over her, to spray her, to mark her, and she did at least appear to be fully satisfied as he pumped his thick white cream over her stomach, her chest and her face.

And afterwards, as she was showing him out, she thanked him for what she described as an amazing time.

"You enjoy dominating a woman, Robert?" she asked him, and perhaps he was paranoid, but the question sounded to Jonah as though she suspected something was up with him.

"I do," he said simply.

She gave a slow, considered nod. "You are very tender, very... respectful...

when you do it," she said. He was about to make some kind of protest, fearing she was unhappy with his level of dominance, but she added: "That is how it should be. You're not a bully, you're not an asshole, you clearly understand the true power and responsibility of dominance."

Her eyes flicked over his face, impressed at him, it would seem.

Jonah felt curiously relieved, as though he had passed some kind of test. He said,

"I do as a woman wants. When I'm with someone, I just want to satisfy her."

She nodded again. "And if she wants you to submit to her?"

"I would do everything in my power to please her."

The corners of her lips curled up in a faint smile at that, and before she wished him well and a good night, closing the door on him, she said, "You're a special find, Robert. I'm very glad I chose you for tonight."



The hotel lobby was fairly lively with guests checking in despite the late hour, and plenty coming back from evening engagements.

Jonah hunched his shoulders and avoided eye contact with anyone around him, feeling certain that people might figure out what he'd been doing there at the hotel. It wasn't as though it was illegal, but for some reason meeting a potentially married woman merely for an hour or two of sex seemed disreputable at best, particularly for an establishment like this.

Was this how call girls and escorts felt after a job at one of these hotels?

Venturing out of the little enclosed street that led from the hotel entrance back to The Strand, Jonah found himself wondering who Gabriella was. Presumably that wasn't her real name. Everything about her suggested to him that she was wealthy—she wasn't just faking it by buying luxurious underwear and booking a lavish room in a top hotel.

Was she married? Would she tell him she wasn't for that night only, unless she did have a husband somewhere?

Turning left on The Strand toward Trafalgar Square, he could still feel all tingly inside, he could still smell her on him, his pulse continued to race and he had a spring in his step at the memory of her face, her body, her embrace, her intimate touch.

Past the Coal Hole pub, he felt the mobile phone in his pants pocket vibrate, and remembered he was supposed to drop a little text to Emma when he had a chance.

There was a text from her waiting for him.

>So do I get to find out about your date tonight, or are you spending the night?

Xx

He smiled broadly. He'd never known anyone like Emma before. Were they actually dating? Sometimes it seemed like it, except for the obvious

fact that he was continuing to sleep with a ton of other women. Well, some people did date that way, non-exclusively, until they decided to go steady with their boyfriend or

girlfriend.

Emma certainly wanted him, certainly wanted to spend time with him, to fool around with him, to sleep with him. But she didn't get jealous at all about the other women he was seeing—in fact, it was completely the other way, she couldn't get enough of it.

Maybe they were just friends with benefits, that most mythical of all relationship types.

Jonah smiled, he probably couldn't talk to her about what their relationship status was, or he'd probably frighten her off. Emma did not seem like the settling down, commitment-craving type, at least not at this stage in her life.

He texted her back—well, it was only polite. He could have told her he was spending the night with his latest date, but in all honesty, if Emma wanted to see him that night, he would happily agree to it.

> *On my way home already, see you there later? Xx* It was only a moment or two before the reply came:

> *Count on it. I hope you have some energy left for me ;-)* He felt a little tickle of arousal down below at that, at the thought that a pretty blonde temptress would now be preparing to travel down to see him, to sleep with him.

Itching to get home, now, Jonah took a left turn off The Strand and into a small side street he hoped might prove a shortcut to the Embankment Tube station.

Perhaps it was because it was an empty street at that time in the night that he suddenly felt his hair standing up on end.

Further on down the little street, he had the eerie sense that he was being watched.

The street was lined with tidy Georgian brick- and stone-clad buildings, but some of the buildings he was passing were shrouded in scaffolding, enclosing their renovations. It was enough to provide cover for anyone who might be following him.

He quickened his step, hoping he was just being paranoid. Who would want to follow him, right? The police? They could monitor him fairly easily through Detective Mulray. The newspapers? That reporter, Harold Keeley, who'd confronted him in the Hilton? Hardly. He thought it was probably a ludicrous ego that made him even consider the possibility that someone might care enough to follow him.

And the killer couldn't possibly know of his own personal investigation yet, could she?

Perhaps it was MI5. The domestic spy network was listening in on everyone's phone calls and perusing their emails completely illegally, so why not follow random people on the streets as well?

At the end of the street, the road didn't reach the park of Victoria Embankment Gardens as he was hoping, but veered right, under one of the neoclassical buildings. Adelphi Terrace, the street sign read. It overlooked the park and its dark trees, and to the left there was a set of stone steps that probably led down to the park, but right now Jonah did not feel that represented a safe way to go. He had visions borne of horror movies of being mugged if he walked into such a well-concealed little corner.

He turned right and continued on through the underpass beneath whatever building it was, and found that the street—Terrace, whatever it was—actually turned back on itself, so that he ended up walking around three sides of a block he could have avoided.

Returning to a street he really did hope would take him to the Tube station, he took a left turn—but then suddenly saw movement behind him, from Adelphi Terrace.

Jonah felt a jolt of shock shoot through his chest. He really was being followed.

Why would someone just happen to walk the same, pointless route he'd just taken around the block?

He turned left, and 20 yards along the street was a break in the railings into a building entrance that offered him quick, easy concealment.

He darted in, and pressed himself up against the wall. His heart was pounding as he waited, listening, watching.

Low traffic noise from The Strand and from the nearby Victoria Embankment was split by the shrill siren of an emergency vehicle passing by, but then the relative silence returned. He could hear the footsteps approaching—the smart clicks that patent-leather shoes might make.

Jonah held his breath, and pushed himself further into the building entrance—

more like a little cubbyhole, with the actual door on the righthand wall. In the darkness, it provided a perfect place to hide from someone who wasn't expecting you to hide.

A man walked purposefully by. He was wearing a suit, a tie. A large man, not one to be messed with. Jonah didn't really catch his face, but edging out onto the street behind him, he saw the man looking this way and that, searching for something. A mark who had gone astray, perhaps.

Who was he? Was he really following Jonah, or had he just come up the steps from the street or the park below?

Jonah now quietly followed him, turning the tables if indeed the man had been monitoring his own movements. A couple blocks further on, the street turned into the little pedestrianized street running down alongside Charing Cross Station, from The Strand to Embankment Station. The man, whoever he was, seemed to loosen up, relax, and turned right to melt into the flow of people.

Had he just given up, accepting he'd lost his target? Or had Jonah just imagined that he had been following him?

Jonah was left feeling disturbed, nevertheless, but turned the opposite way, heading for the Tube station with hopes that Emma might soon provide distraction for his paranoid mind.

And then—

“Hey, watch where you’re going!”

In the darkness, a man walked straight into him, knocking the wind right out of him, the surprising force of the unexpected blow pitching him clean off his feet.

Shock gripped him as he lost his balance and hit the paving slab, then momentary panic hit as he found himself unable to breathe.

Just winded, just winded, he told himself, trying to calm down, focus on breathing. He hadn’t been properly winded for ages—as far back as school rugby games, probably—which simply made it all the more startling to him.

It was a nasty few moments, but he just had to keep forcing his lungs to restart.

“You all right, mate?”

And at last, the glorious flow of oxygen returned to his burning lungs, and he gasped in as much air as he could.

“Yes, just winded I think. Thank you.”

It wasn’t the man who had hit him that stopped to check that he was all right.

Just a couple of good Samaritans. He’d only seen a brief glimpse of the man—a large guy, stocky, probably forty- or fifty-something, wearing a nondescript suit.

Whoever he was, he was long gone by the time Jonah felt strong enough to haul himself back up.

Chances are, he was just a creep not watching where he was going. But the blow had been so hard, sending Jonah sprawling in such spectacular fashion, the guy must have known he’d hit him.

The fact he hadn’t stopped to even see if Jonah was all right made him suspect the guy had done it on purpose.

It couldn't have been the same man who had been following him, could it? Had they been working together? Was this all to send Jonah some kind of message?

Two

"The estate agent has keys to the flat, right? They don't need you there..."

"Yes—look, I've got to go, Dad, I've got a meeting."

Jonah was on the phone to his father for the first time in ages when he saw her.

He was in the Shepherd's Bush area of West London, where he'd been walking purposefully up the busy Uxbridge Road from the Central Line Tube station, dodging the teeming multitude on their way home from work or heading for an evening shopping expedition at the Westfield Centre, or perhaps an early start to their Friday night out in a bar along Shepherd's Bush Common.

Up under the bridge bearing the Hammersmith & City Line, past Shepherd's Bush Market, he turned the corner by a 24-hour convenience store into a side street of residential housing, where a certain Lily Foster lived. He even felt a little nervous at the prospect of meeting her properly, talking to her about her husband, the murders.

"Call me tonight, Jonah. And look, you shouldn't still be dwelling on it all so much."

"Yes, Dad."

"Get back to Oxford—finish your PhD."

Stanlake Road was among a small lattice of streets nestled between the old BBC

Television studios and Queens Park Rangers' football stadium, a fairly narrow street crowded by the cars parked on either side, with a few slender trees and bushes sprouting from the sides to offer a comforting splash of green.

Lily Foster lived in a squat row of terraced houses built of yellowish London brick, with white mock-Georgian style embellishments that caught the gentle orange from the late afternoon light.

As he approached her address, he could see someone quite familiar waiting for

him, leaning up against a dark blue unmarked Ford Focus parked right opposite the address he'd come to visit.

"Call you tonight, Dad," he said, hanging up the phone.

"Fancy seeing you here."

It was inevitable he'd bump into her again, of course, and he should certainly have expected some kind of run-in considering the fact she'd engineered this meeting with Lily in the first place. He was a little surprised just how strong the jolt of heat in his chest was as he laid eyes on DI Mulray again.

She had dark rings under those impossibly large eyes, as though sleep had been hard to come by recently. Her cocoa hair was looser and a little more unkempt in its ponytail than the last time he'd seen her, adding to the image of a police detective on stakeout duty. Nevertheless, she still looked absolutely stunning.

She'd applied a touch more make-up than the last time he'd seen her, he thought.

Had also unfastened a couple of buttons of her blouse again. God, she made him feel like a schoolboy again, with an uncontrolled crush on a girl he could never have.

"Detective, nice to see you again," he said, pausing across the street from where she stood.

Looking a touch pleased with herself for being able to manipulate him so easily, she said, "I had a feeling you might happen by."

Jonah nodded, trying so hard to seem cool and casual while not obviously trying hard to appear cool and casual. "Seems as though you'd rather like me to have a quiet chat with Mrs Foster," he said.

“It’s not my place to tell you who to talk to.”

“But maybe the two of us have something in common?”

“She doesn’t know anything about her husband’s recent dating history. But it seems both of them were a little on the wild side before the kid came along.”

“Wild? Like swingers? She told you that?”

“She avoided the question enough. I happened to mention your idea about the website, though, and then she went completely quiet.”

Jonah said, “She was a journalist, you know? Before the kid. They both were.

She probably assumes if she told you any of the details, it would find its way into the press.”

Mulray nodded, unable to deny that the links between the police and the press were well established, there was no hiding the risk of intimate details from those close to a crime leaking into the pages of the newspapers. Particularly if any of the brains in the force thought exposing sordid details might prompt someone to come forward with useful information.

“We don’t need to know the details if they’re not relevant,” she said, her smile gone. “But it would be useful to know if that website angle of yours has relevance.”

“I would think it would be. Tell me, if you’re so certain she’s keeping something back from the investigation, why don’t you just force her to talk?”

“Force her?”

“I don’t know. Say you’ll arrest her for perverting the course of justice if she doesn’t tell you everything.”

Mulray gave him a wry smile. “You know what the first thing out of my mouth would be if I arrested her for not answering my questions?”

Jonah nodded. “You have the right to remain silent, anything you say can be... “

She laughed. “You’ve been watching too much Law & Order. That’s the American one. The Miranda Rights.”

Mulray stifled a yawn, and Jonah could see it wasn’t because he was tedious company, this detective was exhausted. What was a liaison officer doing that was limiting her sleep so much?

She gave Jonah a serious look. “I knew Lily a little... and I suppose Julian too...

a while back. Long before all this.”

“And you’re allowed to act as liaison officer?”

“I’m not investigating her, my role is only to keep her informed, provide help if she needs it. It’s an advantage if she can get on with me.”

“And you really think I can get something out of her you can’t?”

“You’re not police, you’re not media. You can connect with her on a sympathetic level.”

He nodded. He felt a little flicker inside his chest of something he thought might be contentment. Was that from being useful to this particular detective?

“Does she know you’re using me to get at her secrets?”

“She may have worked it out. She may just need a sounding board, Mr Fielding: a last piece of neutral advice before she does decide to talk to us again.”

Jonah said, “Well, a sounding board I can be. And you can call me Jonah, if you like, Detective.”

“Thank you,” she said, adding: “Mr Fielding.”

He gave a slight nod, accepting her subtext without question, and turned to resume his approach to Lily Foster’s house.

“You want to be careful with her, Mr Fielding,” he heard the Detective call across the road now.

He paused, turning around. “Careful?”

“Bit of a man-eater, before her kid came along,” there was fire in Mulray’s eyes as he looked back at her, and for some reason it reminded Jonah of the moments after she’d seen him naked in the shower back at Nate’s apartment. She added,

“Unless you go in for that sort of thing.”

“I can handle myself,” he said with a mischievous smile.

Mulray nodded, and he could see her entirely fail to prevent herself from smiling back at him. “She hasn’t had... company... in a while,” she warned.

And Jonah teased, “Well, I can be very good company.”

Three

He felt her eyes on his back as he climbed the handful of steps to the front door of the house.

The door opened quietly to reveal the intelligent yet jaded brown eyes of the woman he had met very briefly in the cemetery the other day. Her pretty face seemed to light up on seeing who it was calling at her door, an expression that might even have been relief, that she finally had the chance to talk to someone else who was going through exactly what she was.

“Mrs Foster,” he said.

“Lily, please,” she said, smiling, stepping back to open the door for him. “It’s good to see you again, Jonah.”

“Likewise.”

He stepped inside, past Lily Foster, receiving a burst of her Chanel No.5 as he passed by her.

“Can I get you a coffee or anything?”

“Tea, please, if you’ve got it,” he said.

Inside, Jonah paused within a narrow yet tall hallway, as Lily closed the front door and led him down past a small living room and a set of stairs, through to a modest kitchen.

The house was pervaded by a warm sense of middle-class homeliness, her gentle floral scent in the air attempting to conceal the slightly earthy traces of a cat or a young child.

The kitchen was well kept, and though space was at a premium as with most London properties, it was laid out to maximize the potential. He thought for a young mother, this place was remarkably neat and clutter-free. It made him

wonder if she had intentions of selling, feeling the need to get away from this place and its haunting memories.

“You’ll have to excuse the mess—I don’t often have visitors these days,” Lily said, making Jonah smile because of the neatness of her home, particularly compared to his own hole back in Oxford, or even Nate’s apartment since he’d been staying there, trying to get through all the packing.

“You have a lovely home,” he said, making her smile again as she fetched tea and coffee.

“It’s getting a little bit out of my financial means now,” she said, “but Julian did have a little life insurance tucked away, once the paperwork gets sorted out.”

Lily was well-spoken, Jonah thought, her velvety alto voice quite alluring in its own right. In fact, her whole appearance brought to mind questions concerning why her husband might have felt the need to make use of an adult encounters website, if indeed that was the case.

“Aaron’s out with his grandmother this afternoon,” she was saying as she moved about the kitchen to fix a mug of coffee for herself and a cup of Earl Grey for her guest. Her voice betrayed her relief at having time off from the hassles of childcare.

“It’s very good of you to see me,” Jonah said. “I know how hard it is to even think about all this.”

“I think about it all day, every day anyway,” she said.

Jonah nodded. “Nobody else really understands, right? Or else, they’re family, and there are certain things you just can’t... open up about—”

Lily looked as though she might cry, but was attempting to hold back the tears while concealing her efforts to do so. She tilted her head as she looked at him for a moment, before the kettle boiled and she was distracted again.

“I’ve been finding things out about my brother I never had a clue about,” Jonah was saying, trying to keep conversation ticking over, perhaps persuade her he was safe, with a little down-to-earth honesty. “It’s not really something I’ve been able to talk about with my family.”

“The website,” Lily said, prompting. “What you were saying on the phone—”

He nodded. “It’s not something I need my parents to know, if possible.”

“And what do you think of him for using that website?”

Jonah felt as though she were testing him: any judgment against his brother might also reflect poorly on her husband, if he had been using the same website.

“It’s just what people do these days,” he said, and saw her visibly relax. “You know, I’ve even checked it out a little myself, to try to make sense of things.”

“You’ve met someone through the website?”

“A few people so far, actually.”

Lily briefly raised her eyebrows at that. “And yet you think that’s how your brother met his killer—you’re not afraid you’ll bump into her too?”

“A big part of me is hoping I will.”

Lily nodded, lips pursed in thought. Leaning over the dark granite kitchen countertop towards him, intentionally or unintentionally offering him a hint of her cleavage, she stirred Jonah's tea with a spoon, then without thinking used the same spoon to stir her own coffee. Perhaps influenced by his glimpse down her top, Jonah thought it was strange a husband might want to cheat on a wife like her.

"The police seem to think you're meddling in things," Lily said, bringing over the drinks and perching on the chair opposite him.

"I like to think I'm being helpful. Might turn up a clue of some kind, one way or the other."

"You've told them about the website?"

Jonah sipped his drink, flinching slightly from the heat. "I thought I ought to.

They don't seem interested. It's a big reason why I'm meddling. But I was talking to Nate just before he went out on that last night, and he was going to meet someone he'd contacted through that website."

"How do they not consider that good evidence?"

He shrugged, "Because there's no evidence on any computer that he ever even looked at that website."

"Because he didn't use his own computer to—"

"No, because the website caters particularly to adulterous encounters, so it's specifically designed to provide zero evidence if any divorce lawyers come a-knocking."

Lily nodded her understanding. Sitting across from him, Jonah got the impression she'd attempted to distract attention from the shadows under her eyes with a touch of eyeliner and lipstick, yet not to the point of affecting her general sense of elegance.

She wore a fairly casual thin claret-colored v-neck sweater with a white shirt underneath, but the way the buttons were unfastened down to the glimpse of black bra beneath suggested to Jonah that she might be

looking for more than just distraction. It was a trick that made him think of Mulray.

And thinking of Mulray made him recall the detective's warning that this woman, despite her overall air of sophistication, was a "man-eater".

"I couldn't talk to the police about the website," she said after a sip of coffee, and her sudden admission surprised him. "Even though Detective Mulray...

well, she's friendly, you know? I just couldn't bring myself to..."

Jonah said, "You're sure your husband was using it, then?"

She looked up at him, her brown eyes suddenly seeming so sharp, so dark. "We both were," she said, another frightened check that he wasn't sitting there judging her.

Jonah offered only an empathetic smile. He said, "You were using it together?"

Or... were you both... did he know you were using it too?"

Lily paused, her eyes glancing away as if seeking inspiration for her final decision on whether to trust this stranger, to open up as she hadn't before. Then she locked her eyes on his, appearing determined.

"All that was before Aaron was born," she said. "But recently..."

"You think he started using the website again?"

She looked at him, tired eyes flickering over his features, always trying to read him.

"A few times in the months before he died... I did suspect him, I suppose," she said. "Seeing how it used to be, before Aaron came along, I could hardly be angry with him, though. With Aaron around, it wasn't as though I had the energy any more."

"So you didn't talk to him about your suspicions?"

She shook her head.

“But he didn’t say for certain he was doing it again? Dating other women?”

“What did I care? It kept him happy. I guess it hurt a little that he didn’t tell me... Before Aaron... well, we used to tell each other everything. And when we did it, mostly we did it together.”

“Together?”

“That’s how it started, I suppose,” she said, gripping her coffee mug with both hands as though it leant her security while she opened up to this stranger. “We’d been together a few years, marriage seemed the next logical thing, but by then...

well, you know how it is.”

Jonah didn’t, not having been married, but nodded more to encourage her to go on.

“Well, I wanted children,” she said. “By then we were hardly having sex more than once every few months. In hindsight, I can see neither of us were really making an effort—and by that stage in a relationship, you have to accept it’s going to take more than simply laying eyes on each other to get the libido going.”

“So you let him have sex with someone else?”

Lily smiled, but with more than a hint of sadness. “I didn’t know what to do. I read that we needed to communicate more, but where did we start? Two middle-class English people, virtually trained from birth to act as though sex doesn’t exist.”

“What did you do?”

“I saw him wake up one morning with the most enormous erection,” she said.

“Felt like I hadn’t seen anything like that for months, years maybe. I was laughing at him, and he got all flustered, tried to make out it was perfectly common. I told him it most certainly wasn’t common for him.”

“So—”

“So I think I offended him a little, provoked him to be a little more honest than he’d normally be.”

“What did he say?”

“He told me he’d been having a dream, and when I asked him if he’d been dreaming about another woman, he said he’d been dreaming about me sleeping with another man.”

Jonah caught his breath, but did well to conceal his reaction. He noticed Lily blushing, and thought it quite becoming on her.

“He dreamt you were cheating on him—and that gave him an erection?” Jonah asked.

“Seems crazy, right?” she took a big gulp of coffee. “Well, I couldn’t help myself. It was right there, so I climbed right on board. And the next time I felt horny, and my husband didn’t seem to be in the mood, I asked him if he’d had any more dreams recently about someone else fucking me, and sure enough he was suddenly ready to go.”

Jonah felt a little tickle of arousal himself at the image in his head of this sensual woman taunting her husband into sexual activity.

Maybe his sex drive was a little over-egged after starting his campaign using the No Strings website, but there was something unquestionably thrilling about this

quiet, dignified young woman opening up about the steamier side of her life.

“So he suggested you guys should use the No Strings website?” Jonah asked her.

Lily shook her head. “It was a different one to start with. This was a little while before Aaron came along, and he’s three now. Later on, as we learned more about the lifestyle, we were pointed in that direction...”

“Because it’s more for married people?”

“Because it’s 100% discreet.” She looked at Jonah quite seriously. “Are you going to tell the police about this?”

“What, Mulray?”

“She probably knows, anyway, or at least suspects.”

“She... we... really just want to know that this website is involved. I’m sure we wouldn’t need to divulge any details.”

The brunette nodded. “We’re journalists, you see. Or were journalists... if it got out, the media will probably love dragging our names through the mud.”

Jonah did not feel entirely comfortable advising this poor woman to open up to the police, to risk damaging their reputations and provoke some kind of smutty tabloid newspaper feeding frenzy. But he needed some confirmation that it wasn’t just his own sad attempts to make his brother’s murder seem significant that was leading to this conclusion about a serial killer hunting her prey through this website.

He suddenly had a thought.

“Have you heard much about the progress the police have been making in the case?” he asked her.

She shook her head. “Not much, was the last I heard.”

Jonah said, “What I’ve heard—not from Mulray, mind you—is that the police are beginning to think prostitution may be involved.”

“Prostitution?”

Lily looked as horrified as Jonah had felt when the idea had first been raised by that Guardian journalist back in the Hilton.

“So you see, it may be that fooling around with an online dating website...”

She nodded. “It may not be the worst damage for our reputations. Well, perhaps I should tell Mulray everything.”

Drinks finished, Lily said, “I was wondering if you’d like to see his things.”

“I’m sorry?”

“His papers, you know... in case you uncover something I’ve missed. There was a lot the police took, of course, but they’ve returned most of it.”

“Right.”

Lily smiled. “If you’re going to meddle, you might as well meddle properly.”

“Of course,” he said, returning her smile, feeling something in her warm eyes that was more than just two people with a common grief. “I don’t want to take up too much of your time, though...”

“Oh don’t worry about that,” she said, and gave him the impression he was doing her a favor by sticking around. Perhaps she’d been a little starved for company since her husband had gone, other than that of her little boy. Jonah got the feeling there was more to find out from her than simply whether or not her husband had been using the No Strings website. “Come on, most of it’s in his office.”



Upstairs, Lily showed him into a little box room barely large enough for a double bed, into which were crammed a couple of large bookshelves, a small filing cabinet and desk on which various papers, bills and items of correspondence lay in neat piles.

“You’re both journalists, but you don’t have a computer in the house?” Jonah asked her, as he ran his eyes along the books on the shelves, which appeared to be mostly biographies.

“I haven’t really done any of that since Aaron was born,” she said, hugging the doorway as she watched him take a seat at the desk, scanning over the papers laid out over its surface. “To be honest I’ve... lost touch with that part of my life.”

“And your husband?”

“Julian objected to the need to bring his work home, so he refused to get one practically on principle. He wrote obituaries, you know?”

Jonah nodded. “I think I read that.”

“He mostly wrote and researched pieces for the database—about people who were still alive, so they could be quickly slotted into the paper once they died.”

“Nice.”

“People think when you get a job on a national newspaper that it must be a glamorous thing, All the President’s Men and all that. Julian got very disillusioned.”

Standing in the doorway, she was twirling a rogue strand of her dark hair, which only helped lead his eyes down to her nicely rounded breasts.

“And you guys don’t ever feel the need to email anyone?”

Lily shrugged, “Neither of our families ever really got to grips with 21 st Century communications. The older ones, anyway. The younger ones are all on Facebook, and I can’t deal with all that.”

Even coming from his Oxford academic background, where the people he had been around the whole time had seemed similarly reluctant to engage with the modern world, it was surprising to Jonah.

Scanning the various papers on the desk, even peering into the stacks, he felt a little out of his depth. This would need time to pour over.

On this table seemed to be so many details of this small family now torn apart by violent crime—their spending habits, their financial plans, their interests and arrangements for developing their child. Yet how could he hope to weed out something of use?

It was information overload.

But then, had he really expected to uncover something the professionals had missed? That was plain arrogance, wasn’t it?

The website, though. All thoughts had to come back to the website.

“When you used the website before,” he said, “did you use it with him? How did that go?”

“He mostly did it from work, I think,” Lily said. “I suppose what you were saying about it not leaving any trace that you’ve used it. The first few times, we went to one of those Internet cafes.”

“How did it all start? Do you mind my asking?”

She shrugged. “We’d been talking about it for weeks, months maybe. Just once, we thought we might try something out for real.”

“And it was still the idea of you sleeping with someone else, right? Not Julian taking another woman as well?”

Jonah felt himself prying, and it seemed a little wrong, and yet she wasn’t stopping him. It was somehow fascinating to him, even beyond the fact that it was new information about one of the other victims now pouring forth.

“Before Aaron came along, he was never interested in other women. He was a voyeur, I suppose you’d say. And I was his favorite subject.”

She seemed to push out her chest at that, as though trying to make Jonah believe she might be someone’s obsession. He could fully understand the obsession, he couldn’t fully understand the need to watch her with other men.

“Did the fantasy appeal to you as well?”

Lily folded her arms. “Well, probably not quite to the same level, but a girl likes the idea of a little male attention, you know. To start with, I was just hoping to prolong his interest so we could have a baby. Later... it was nice...”

“And there were men who would allow Julian to watch them with you?”

“Yes. It wasn’t always easy to find them, but they were there.”

From somewhere downstairs, they heard the telephone ring. It was an old-style bell tone, which added to the sense that Julian Foster had been something of a Luddite.

Lily excused herself, leaving him alone in the little room, though he could do little to take advantage of the situation other than perform a rapid search for anything of interest.

There didn't seem to be any clues in the bookshelves, either. A fairly random selection of personalities appeared to be represented by the various biographical tomes—the closest titles featured authorized or unauthorized histories of Bill Clinton, Ingrid Bergman, Prince Charles, Mick Jagger, Elizabeth Taylor, Brad Pitt and John Major.

There were a couple of racier volumes on the bottom shelf, tucked away in the shadows, with titles like “The Unfaithful Housewife”, “Something Forbidden”,

“Taken by a Stranger”. They weren't exactly unusual for someone who toyed with the whole swinging thing.

From downstairs, from the snippets of Lily's conversation he caught, he could tell she was speaking with someone about her son, most likely the grandmother.

Was it time to head home? He felt as though he needed a little more time to talk to Lily about the website and the whole extramarital thing, though he also knew that part of his desire to talk with her more was simply because she was so bewitching as a woman.

However, he really didn't want to intrude on a busy mother's time, particularly one grieving a lost husband.

Waiting for Lily to hang up, considering whether to ask to come back another time, whether he'd gain anything useful out of all these papers and books, Jonah's eye fell on six identical paperback books sitting in the bottom lefthand corner, on the shelf where the adult titles were sitting.

“The Watchers”—that was the title. Alex Higson was the author.

He reached for the nearest copy. Why would Julian have six identical copies of a book that, from the lingerie model adorning the cover, appeared to be erotica?

Were they an author's complimentary copies? So Julian Foster was Alex Higson?

He heard Lily hang up, replacing the handset of a land-line phone in its cradle, a sound that seemed so archaic in this age of cordless, wireless and mobile phones.

Then, just as the creaks suggested she was returning upstairs to him, something caught his eye in the wastepaper basket.

It was a photograph of Julian Foster.

Jonah fished it out: a smiling, carefree Julian, one from happier times.

Why was it in the trash?

He turned his shoulder to the doorway and quickly slipped his wallet out of his trouser pocket, tucking the picture into it along with the fraying wad of receipts and reminders.

He jumped as Lily now appeared.

“Oh, you found Julian’s book,” she smiled.

“Julian wrote a book? This book?”

Lily’s eyes flashed. “Scandalous, right? It didn’t do terribly well, though. I think that was it for his fiction ambitions.” She nodded towards the stairs and, presumably, the phone, then said, “That was my mother-in-law, she’s going to keep Aaron for the night. D’you fancy a bite to eat?”

More time to gently grill Lily Foster about her strange life with her husband? It wasn’t a difficult decision for Jonah.

Four

Jonah was a little surprised that she’d apparently changed her plans to have dinner with him, but in her melancholy face he recognized the hint of desperation to connect with another human being.

She seemed almost relieved when he accepted her invitation.

There was no sign of Mulray or her Ford Focus as they stepped out of the house to stroll round to a little Indian restaurant nearby. Lily took the opportunity of the walk to ask Jonah about his own personal situation as

they went, asking where he was living, about his occupation and even asking whether he was single.

The restaurant appeared to have a hopeless marketing strategy judging by the lack of diners, but the food was good. Sitting in a velvet-cushioned booth towards the back of the place, they had plenty of privacy once the waiter had taken their order.

“You’ll like it,” she was saying after he’d opted for her recommendation, a none-too-spicy pasanda.

“I bet,” he said, enjoying the warmth that had built between them during their brief time together.

Then she said, “Thank you, Jonah.”

“For what?” he raised an eyebrow.

She took a deep breath and just looked at him a moment, soulful eyes perusing his face, full lips not quite sure whether to maintain her smile. “In the last few months, I’ve had my three-year-old son and my mother-in-law to talk to, other than police or pushy journalists.”

Jonah nodded. “I’ve probably been prying a little too much as well,” he said in full disclosure. “I’m just not very good at the whole interrogation thing.”

“I don’t feel as though I’m going to get in trouble when you’re doing the questioning. It’s more like... therapy.”

With a large glass of Kingfisher lager placed in front of him, and a glass of red for Lily, Jonah asked her about the kinds of people she’d met with or without her husband through her Internet dating before Aaron had come along.

“They all seemed very normal on the surface,” she said. “I guess from the start, I assumed it was us—well, Julian really—that was a little on the strange side.”

“Before,” Jonah said, “you were saying you didn’t have any involvement in setting up the dates?”

She shook her head. “I suppose... I felt if I left it all up to him, he couldn’t be angry with me—because it would have been him setting it all up.”

“And was he jealous?”

“He said he felt a little jealous, deep down, but that was part of the attraction for him. I never really understood it, but I did love him. I wanted him to be happy—

and goodness knows he wasn’t happy at work, and I hadn’t been able to keep him much interested in sex before we tried the website.”

“Were the guys you met happy for your husband to tag along? You didn’t surprise any of them with your... unconventional requests?”

“Oh, they knew what they were getting into,” Lily gave a half smile, and he thought there was a little lust in her wistful look. “Julian didn’t hide in the closet or anything like that, or jump out on them when I got them home. We all went out together first, test the waters. In fact, this restaurant was often the perfect place.”

Jonah felt a little tingle inside his loins at the thought of Lily sitting here in this very place, preparing herself for sex with a stranger. He could understand a man for wanting to see her naked and sprawled across a bed, though the thought that Julian would want another man to be with her was a little odd.

“Sometimes you went on dates without your husband, though, right?”

“Sometimes,” she nodded. “Sometimes the guys Julian was in contact with

wanted to see me on my own first, perhaps even have sex with me first, before deciding to try it with him present. Sometimes Julian just seemed to want me to go out on my own, to imagine what I would be doing with someone else, rather than see it for himself.”

Listening to her talking about the strangeness of being with her husband for so long, and then to go out on her own to meet someone else with the express intention of having complete carnal connection with them was fascinating to Jonah, even if he didn’t fully understand the motivations of her husband.

“Did you enjoy it? Dating people outside your marriage?”

“I did,” she said. “I think initially the big question was whether he still loved me, whether he could love me... and want me to do that. But I could always see that he did love me, and when we dated together, I could see he was still interested in me sexually... just in a slightly less conventional way than when we’d started going out.”

“And he went out with other women separately?”

“Only a few times from what I remember,” Lily said. “The first time, I actually ordered him to.”

“Ordered him to?”

She grinned, “I wanted to know what it was like to be on the other end of the equation.”

“And?”

“It was strange. I couldn’t feel bad about him being with someone else, after what we’d already done together, and by then I wasn’t worried he’d stop loving me. I guess I could see something of the excitement he felt when I went off without him—kind of sexy to think someone else was enjoying your partner, who you had on tap any time you felt like it.”

“But you didn’t order him to do it again?”

She shrugged, “Neither of us really saw the need. A couple of times women wanted to meet him alone before deciding whether to join us as a couple—”

“Women joined you as a couple?”

Lily gave him a wicked smile, “What can I say? Julian enjoyed seeing me testing my boundaries. But that was only a few times.”

Jonah said, “Tell me something: you don’t remember going out with anyone who was particularly angry... or afraid, or anything like that? Men or women?”

“Nervous,” she said. “We were all nervous, pretty much every time, though it got a little easier after a while.”

She took a long sip of wine, then said, “I’m sorry—I’m not being much help, am I? It would be great if I could say there was a disturbing woman we met, and stalked us or something...”

Jonah glanced away, wondering if anyone might be watching him have dinner with Lily Foster. “No, of course you’re helping,” he said. “Probably doesn’t help I don’t really know what to ask. I guess I just want... to get a feel for what kind of people you met.”

“They seemed really quite normal, I’m afraid,” she said. “I mean, other than their need to meet strangers for sex, of course. I’m not sure what I can say. The first guy was a student, liked older women. I wasn’t much older than him, really.

People like him, it was just easier to go out with women through a dating site, less chance of making an idiot out of himself.”

“Makes sense.”

“He was nice,” she said, her voice sounding suddenly somehow far away as she recalled that first time, her fingers twirling that rogue strand of her hair again.

“He said married women were a little more exciting than single girls, ‘cause they were so desperate for a change from their husbands. He said it was the first time he’d met with a couple, though.”

“Julian handled it okay? With that guy, the others...”

“He was very calm. We had dinner, drinks, and it was as though the guy was a colleague, or something like that. Julian got on pretty well with people—he could never bother to have arguments. It got so I’d forget the whole reason we were having drinks with these guys, and then as the night drew on, he’d flash me

this questioning look, and suddenly I’d get this hot flush as I remembered he wanted me to have sex with this guy.”

“And that’s how it happened? He’d ask you, and then you all went back to the house?”

Lily shrugged. “We’d stroll on back to the house talking about some inane subject like football or art or the price of steel—Julian had so many biographies in his head, he could talk to anyone about anything. We’d get home, go upstairs, and suddenly we’d be in the bedroom, and a stranger would be helping me take off my clothes.”

She looked across the table at Jonah, and there was fire in her eyes. She enjoyed telling him the sordid details, it seemed. Only the arrival of their food, now, stopped her.

Was Jonah wrong to be attracted to her? Was he taking advantage of a vulnerable woman by enjoying her underlying exhibitionist streak?



Perhaps distracted by the food, the rest of the dinner conversation flitted away from the subject at hand to friendlier talking points, including Lily’s son Aaron and Jonah’s time at Oxford.

She seemed most amused that his PhD was about the migratory habits of birds, but now he’d effectively stepped away from all that, Jonah found no real interest in talking about his thesis subject.

By the time the meal was over, a few more drinks taken, and the bill out of the way, Jonah felt Lily’s demeanor had become almost cheerful, though she could never quite let go of that glimmer of sadness in the corner of her eye.

So as they came to step out into the dark street, Lily suggested a drink at the Crown a couple of blocks over, and Jonah couldn’t see why not.

She linked her arm in his, such that he could detect her perfume in the still night air.

“God, I haven’t been able to let my hair down like this since... I can’t remember when,” she said.

“You know, you can always give me a call sometimes, you ever feel the need for a quick drink,” Jonah said, and he was being serious.

She smiled. “I may take you up on that offer.”

The pub was dark and old and comfortable, with mostly locals enjoying the place despite the Friday evening peak hour.

Another pint of beer for Jonah and a glass of Chianti for Lily, and they managed to find a dark little corner for some privacy.

“Was this another of your old haunts?” Jonah asked, for something to start the conversation rolling again, rather than specifically looking to turn the conversation back to business.

“It was,” she said. “If they turned out to be unpleasant, we could just sneak around the bar and slip out unnoticed, it’s so gloomy in here.”

Jonah took a sip of his sharp lager. “Did you ever feel angry he wanted to get involved with other people?”

She sniffed, sipped her red wine. “Never angry. Confused, to start with. Men are supposed to want threesomes with two women, aren’t they? But I guess a lot of the time it wasn’t strictly a threesome, Julian liked to watch.”

“When you were with another woman, did he stick to watching then, too?”

She looked across at Jonah, once again examining his face for signs of disapproval or judgment. It seemed being with another woman represented another step further in stretching the boundaries of her otherwise cozy middle-class life, and she needed to be sure she was in completely safe company before admitting anything.

Jonah could only try to give her the strong impression that he was not in the slightest bit interested in judging her, whatever she’d done or whatever she liked doing.

Just so long as murder wasn’t part of her repertoire.

A moment looking at his neutral expression, and she relaxed a little. “There were only a few women,” she said. “Mostly it was guys, and it wasn’t until a fair few months down the road that Julian invited the first woman to join us.”

“He was worried you’d be jealous?”

“He was always worried what I’d think,” she said. “Julian wasn’t a monster, you know—he did genuinely care how I felt. He only suggested any of it in the first place because he was worried our sex life had run aground. And it had, I wouldn’t quibble with that.”

“How did it go, when it happened?”

“Mostly,” she said. “We’d come home—so nervous, even after a fair amount of booze. Julian would tell me to take our guest up to the bedroom and get started, while he fetched some drinks. The first few times, I just went up with the guys and we just talked while we waited for Julian to come up with the drinks, but after a while I guess I got more comfortable with it, so he’d come up, maybe find me undressed, in the arms of the other guy... or whatever.”

She cast another quick glance to see that Jonah wasn’t horrified, and that no one else in the pub was listening in, though the music would have made it impossible for even the most dedicated eavesdroppers.

Then she said, “Julian used to sit in our armchair, mostly, sipping a tumbler of scotch while he watched me on the bed with those guys. I guess I did enjoy it.

The attention, the sex.”

Jonah nodded, and thought that her defiant expression seemed to have ignited into unabashed delight at revealing all these shocking things to another soul.

“A lot of them Julian found happened to be quite well endowed,” she said, then feeling a little bolder: “I guess Julian liked a challenge, liked seeing me stretched by a big guy.”

“But with the women, did he tend to join in, or only watch?”

“He was a voyeur mostly,” another sip of wine. “I was always surprised—he just liked watching me. I even said to him a few times, he should come over, join us.

He just liked seeing me burying my face between some girl’s thighs.”

“And you liked it?”

“I didn’t have a problem with it.”

Then she was blushing, again, contradicting her earlier defiance. Jonah suggested he refill their drinks. “Hurry back—if you dare,” she said, her face creasing into an impish grin.



The bar had three sides, with a central peninsula bearing the usual Technicolor array of different alcoholic choices, but as the staff appeared to be camped out on the other side of the room to himself and Lily, Jonah had to walk all the way around there to have any hope of being served.

After a moment or two waiting, he was surprised by a familiar voice beside him.

“Well, hello there, Mr Fielding.”

He caught his breath, but forced himself to conceal his reaction. How had she evaded his notice?

“Detective Inspector,” Jonah also tried hard not to respond to her warm, sweet, cinnamon fragrance as she moved to stand so close to him at the bar, her perfume filled his every breath.

“What are you doing here?”

DI Mulray smiled, “I think I should be asking you that question—this is my local, not yours.”

It wasn’t the easiest thing to play down his response to her: Mulray looked absolutely stunning. No longer in her work suit, tonight she was

letting it all free, from her loose hair to the relatively low-cut top that emphasized, rather than concealed, her modest but shapely cleavage. Even her jeans did more to celebrate her curves than the suit she wore day-to-day.

It only showed how successful she was during her working day to conceal her femininity from the male-dominated world in which she operated.

“So Lily Foster is a neighbor of yours?” he asked her.

“Near enough, as it turns out,” she said.

The DI ordered a pint of London Pride and a gin and tonic, making Jonah wonder who she was with that evening, and even experience a brief stabbing jolt of envy.

“What’re you having?” she asked him, but he politely dismissed her offer as another barman came over to take his own order.

“How are you two getting along?” she asked once the orders were taken, flicking her eyes over towards his table.

“Like the proverbial house on fire,” he said. “I haven’t got an answer for you yet, though.”

Mulray handed her bankcard across the bar to pay for her drinks, and now looked deep into Jonah’s eyes for a moment, as if she might discover his secret.

Then she simply nodded, making it appear like she had her answer, whatever answer it was.

Mulray shrugged, and after typing in her PIN code to complete the purchase of her drinks, looked back at Jonah with those beautiful, large eyes and said, “You know, you might want to spend a little more time with her.”

“Why do I get the feeling you’re trying to be my pimp?”

She smiled.

Jonah felt every bone in his body turn to mush when she looked at him like that.

God, why did she feel the need to hide all this power while she was working?

She could have the whole of the Metropolitan Police eating out of her hand in no time.

“I’m not telling you what to do with her,” she said, and Jonah had to conceal a smile himself as he noticed her blush.

“But presumably you’d want me to walk her home—”

“It would be safer for a lone female.”

“—and perhaps stay for a sneaky glass of wine?”

“Only polite, if she’s asking,” Mulray raised an eyebrow, and then scooped up her drinks, ready to disappear back to the secret hideaway in which she’d been skulking.

“I do try to be polite,” he said.

She gave a quick flash of those dazzling eyes as if to say she knew what he was up to, and how filthy he was to be doing it. But as she turned to go, he stopped her.

“Wait, Detective,” he said.

She paused, looking back.

“One last thing,” he said. “Isn’t that what you detectives are supposed to say?”

“Only the ones with glass eyes and old Macintoshes, Mr Fielding.”

Jonah said, “I just wanted your quick opinion on something.”

“Shoot.”

“Julian Foster was an obituary writer who didn’t like bringing his work home—

so much so that he didn’t have a computer in the house.”

“Right. And?”

“And yet, his bookshelves were stuffed with biographies.”

“He didn’t like to work overtime—doesn’t mean he didn’t find the people he wrote about interesting.”

“I suppose so,” Jonah said. Mulray gave him a perplexed look. He said, “Tell me something—what do Bill Clinton, Ingrid Bergman, Prince Charles, Mick Jagger, Elizabeth Taylor, Brad Pitt and John Major have in common?”

The detective thought for a moment. “They all cheated on their wives—or husbands,” she said.

Jonah nodded, “Interesting.”

Five

Lily batted away his apology for the time it took to return with the drinks, appearing happy enough that he was still there, allowing her a little social contact.

“The service is usually pretty terrible in here,” she said, taking a sizable sip of her drink as though he’d left her to die of thirst. “Actually, that was always something we could say to the people we invited here.”

“That the service is crap?”

“We could say to people hey, we’ve got a nice bottle or two at home, why don’t we just head on back?”

“Subtle,” Jonah said, taking a hefty sip of his beer himself.

She shrugged, “You can only be so subtle when you invite strangers out to have sex with you.”

“Fair enough.”

“Julian and I had this code—if either of us didn’t like the look of whoever it was we were with, we’d just talk about how good the service was in here. You know

—suggesting we should stay here, enjoy—”

“And when you approved of your date?”

“We’d quietly turn the conversation round to the fact the service stinks in here—

then one of us would suggest heading home.”

Jonah took a big gulp of his beer, and now looked behind him to see if he could spot Mulray. Somehow, with the detective around, he felt awkward. He didn’t mind helping her with some intelligence, but preferred not to be watched as he was seeking it.

“Everything okay?” Lily asked, noticing his drifting attention.

Defensive, he blurted out: “I... uh... I was just wondering what you might say if it was me... you know, sitting here on one of those dates.”

Jonah felt the heat of embarrassment flush through his face and neck as he realized he’d been a trifle more suggestive than he’d meant to, since he’d been distracted.

Sure, they were getting along well, and she’d made it perfectly clear she’d been starved of adult male company, but was it really a good idea to seem like he was coming on to her? The important thing was to find out as much as he could about Julian’s dating history, to try to shed light on what kind of person the killer could be.

But Lily merely squeezed the corners of her mouth into a mischievous smirk, and said in a low voice: “I think I already did, didn’t I?”

Jonah felt a tickle of something he thought might be arousal at the sudden look of dark hunger in her eyes.

She picked up her glass and now tipped back her head to sink the rest of her wine, and Jonah felt the heat inside him only intensify. Was she indicating what he thought she was?

“I really do have a nice bottle of wine back home, you know,” she said, in that voice of hers, which was like liquid caramel.

He could feel his manhood thicken between his thighs, sense the change in his breathing, the quickening of his pulse. Was he really willing to cross this boundary with her? Lily Foster was not just a random date, never to be seen again, if it all turned sour.

He looked her in the eyes, and in doing so realized he’d been staring at her cleavage, which somehow appeared a little more prominent, a few more buttons of her shirt unfastened, since he’d been away to fetch the drinks.

He said quietly: “We’re not... in danger of screwing things up here, are we?”

Lily was grinning at the way he’d blushed, knowing she’d caught him staring

exactly where she’d wanted him to stare.

She said calmly: “I won’t be expecting you to adopt my child, Jonah.”

“I suppose not.”

“Two people can have a little fun if they both want to,” she said. “I won’t feel you’re taking advantage of me if you don’t feel I’m taking advantage of you.”

“Deal,” Jonah said.



The night air was a little cold as they wandered back to Lily’s house, but she wasn’t shy in linking her arm in his, pulling him to her while they

walked, with an obviousness to her need that Jonah found faintly thrilling.

As they turned back into Stanlake Road, past the Dominos pizza outlet on one corner, and the convenience store on the other, she thanked him for spending time with her.

“You don’t need to thank me,” he said. “I’ve had a good time.”

“Mulray said you were nice,” she said, squeezing his arm, smiling as though he’d just proposed. “She was right.”

Jonah felt the warmth simmering inside his chest. He said, “I rather think she was hoping I might break down your defenses, get you to open up about whether your husband was using the same website as my brother.”

“Is that what you’re doing? Breaking down my defenses?”

“I am interested in any insight you might have about my brother’s death, sure.

But I won’t give the police any details you might be worried about.”

She sighed, said, “I should speak to them, really. But it’s been helpful talking to you about it first.”

“It probably is a good idea to talk to them again,” he said.

“I just don’t want... well, I suppose I could still be careful exactly what it is I tell them.”

“Sure, you can be careful.”

“Nothing from before... from before we had Aaron... could possibly be relevant, could it?”

Jonah knew what she was getting at. She was opening up to the idea of letting the police have details about what Julian might have been doing recently, without her, but she wanted to keep her own part in his adventures before the

birth of their son a secret. Was she quietly annoyed, even angry, at her husband for wanting to get back into their old sexual exploration without her?

He said: “You have to decide what might be relevant. It’s your choice what to tell the police. But this has all happened over the last year, I suppose. The important thing is, if we can show he was using that website just before he died...”

She nodded, seeming relieved. “If I promised to talk to her again—Murray, I mean—and tell her your website idea might have some bearing on all this...

would you still want to stay with me a little longer... tonight...”

“I’ll stay as long as you want me to stay.”

She squeezed his arm contentedly, the alcohol in her system lending her a little more confidence than he thought she’d have otherwise, as she said, “I was hoping you might still want to probe me for information...”

Jonah felt his cock tingle and stiffen a little further in his trousers. He glanced into her eyes a moment before they headed up the steps to her front door, and then they were both laughing at her double entendre.

Sure, he could see the burning need deep within her, for company, for comfort, for sexual connection with somebody. She’d had such a hard time, she was in dire need of a little physical attention from another human being. But it couldn’t be exploitative for him to fulfill such needs.

As she slipped the key into the front door, Lily put her forefinger to her lips, warning him that the neighbors would hear if they continued being so loud.

Inside the front door, he removed his shoes in deference to Lily doing likewise, and followed her through the hallway to the kitchen again, feeling a frisson of anticipation ripple through him.

Even after his use of the No Strings website, he still found it a little strange that sex was something that people could just go out there and get if they wanted. His experience before coming down from Oxford had suggested it was always so complicated.

The Internet was certainly changing things in society, clarifying the sense that

connecting sexually was an inalienable human right.

Growing up, he'd seen young women encouraged—at least on the surface—to appear so selective when it came to sexual partners, that it seemed on the whole that they didn't need sex, it was just a faintly pleasurable thing they occasionally gave up to the menfolk. The women he'd met through the website had been quite different.

Admittedly, at Oxford he'd generally kept a little too much to himself, but recently he had had his eyes opened to a new kind of people, who needed human connection and simply went out and got it.

"Murray was saying you were good at getting information out of her," Lily was saying as she poured them both glasses of a 2009 Bordeaux.

He said, "I wouldn't say I got much from her. What did she tell you?"

"That she thought you had more than just a need to be updated on the case."

"Wow. She thinks I'm a suspect?"

Lily chuckled, "No. She just thinks you're interfering—maybe that you're using the website yourself so you can be some kind of vigilante."

She was looking at Jonah with some kind of admiration, as though he were some kind of rock star, and she a besotted fan.

He said, "I think she engineered this whole thing as a test."

"Coming to see me?"

Jonah nodded. "She wants to know how far I'm digging."

"I don't have to tell her anything," Lily said, and now pulled off her sweater, apparently warm after coming in from the cold street—her face was certainly flushed, at any rate. There was something insanely thrilling about her pulling off clothing, though.

Jonah said, “It’s a little late for that. Me showing up here at all is the confirmation she needs.”

“She likes you, did you know that?” Lily said, and there wasn’t a hint of jealousy or malice. Jonah wondered if her values, when it came to relationships, had been irrevocably altered by her experimentation with Julian. “When she was talking about you, when she was suggesting I meet with you, it was so obvious she has a thing for you.”

“I doubt that very much.”

“What did you say to her when she visited you, at your apartment?” Lily asked, her face so full of light now as she leaned back against the kitchen counter in a manner that accentuated her curves. “You obviously affected her.”

“Nothing much that I can recall,” he said, his mind drifting back to when Mulray had been watching him through a transparent wall, when he’d been taking a shower.

Lily nodded. “You should ask her out—when all this is over. She’s very pretty.

Completely obsessed with her job, of course, so nothing’ll happen while you’re involved in an active case...”

Jonah said, “You two seem quite close...”

“Oh, well, you know how it is. Goodness knows I hardly speak to anyone else most of the time,” she said, taking another sip of wine. “And I suppose she feels a little sorry for me. Since she lives nearby...”

He thought for a moment to ask about how she’d first met Mulray, since they’d known each other before all this. But the way Lily talked about the Detective made it sound as though she only knew her from her role as liaison officer attached to the murder investigation.

“And she talks to you about the other victims’ relatives, too? Or just me?”

“She mentions others sometimes. Rarely.” Lily glanced at the wine bottle, considering topping up their glasses already, then seemed to think better

of it, and instead flicked her head to suggest they adjourn to the sitting room.

Ensconced at either end of a neat, contemporary beige couch, Jonah felt strangely comfortable with Lily Foster. He hadn't expected to be spending this much time with her, but he was glad he'd stayed.

The way she spoke of Mulray's interest in him appeared to underline the casual nature of her own desire, and it made him feel a little more relaxed, giving him the sense that this was merely fulfilling a physical need, that he wasn't taking advantage of someone in a vulnerable position.

Lily asked him if there was anything more he wanted to know about her husband, and he suddenly felt a sharp sense of guilt, that his mind was careering along thinking what it might be like to venture into Lily's panties, instead of taking full benefit of spending time with her to examine every possible lead her knowledge might reveal.

Trying to keep casual, he asked her: "Did it affect your relationship with Julian?"

After all that... stuff... happened?"

She took a long sip of wine, considering.

Then she said, "I think it was inevitable it was going to affect things. To start with, I just wanted anything that might warm things up between us. When you're married, and you see each other every day, and you're tired all the time from the nine-to-five, sex just gets away from you. And it's difficult to get back—you never feel like your partner's in the mood, and when you're in the mood... well, it seems humiliating to ask."

Lily took another big swig of wine. "I think by the time we got to inviting other people into our bed, things between us had gotten to the stage that anything had to be an improvement."

"You're saying it improved things between you?"

"Is that so wrong? We always loved each other—when we started dating again, we had our intimacy back, and a new shared interest to talk about."

“But you did want a child.”

She shrugged, “Ends justify the means, I suppose.”

He thought her words were slurring a little.

He said, “Forgive me for asking, but Aaron... he was...”

“Julian’s?” Lily laughed, “Now wouldn’t that have been a scandal? No, we did use condoms when it came to other people. Julian was the only one who ever rode me bareback.”

It felt funny to be talking about this. Jonah felt his cock hard between his thighs, and now more than ever felt he almost understood why Julian might have wanted to merely witness his graceful creature making love, rather than simply being the one making love to her. To appreciate her beauty from afar, getting the best view.

She edged closer to him, now offering him a top-up of the Bordeaux, which he gratefully received.

“You said he usually preferred to watch, rather than...”

She nodded. “But afterwards, after a date, for quite a few days he was always still fired up. He liked to talk about it, ask me how it had felt, what I liked about the other man’s... well, we’d talk about it all... and it felt almost like it did when we first met, you know?”

She put the bottle down, and Jonah found himself hoping that she didn’t decide to move back to the end of the couch, away from him.

He asked: “And sometimes, he did join in when you were with someone?”

“There were a few of them that insisted on it,” she said, and Jonah felt his pulse quickening again as Lily stayed close to him, the alcohol offering her a little more confidence. Her low, sultry voice and delicate Chanel No.5 was already doing something to him even before her fingers started leisurely trailing around his thigh.

She said, “The women we went with seemed to insist on it. Some of them said they were only bi-curious, and it was as though they needed Julian to

join us in order to validate themselves.”

“They were only having a little fun with you, they didn’t take it seriously?”

Jonah asked.

“I didn’t mind,” she said, her fingers getting tantalizingly close to Jonah’s hardness now, he felt it twitch as if to tempt her to take it in her clutches. “The

first time we went with another girl, I’d already had so many other men inside me, I no longer had any fear that Julian would stop loving me.”

“And with the men?”

“The men were more interested in having me to themselves, though some of them did want to see me taking more than one guy at a time.”

She looked up into his eyes, to check to see if he was horrified at the thought of her with two men at once. Then her fingers reached the outline of his engorged manhood, nudging into it through his trousers, and she smiled, no longer worried about his opinion of her.

He said softly, “I think I’d want to have you to myself.”

Her smile spread further across her pale face, her eyes really lighting up.

“Well, now you do,” she said, and kissed him.

It was delicate, soft at first. Explorative. Her lips warm, tart from the wine, opening to suck on his bottom lip, her head tilted, nose brushing against his cheek, breath dancing on his skin.

Her eyes flickered open momentarily, to check on his response, but then as he began actively exploring her mouth himself, she relaxed, her hand reaching for his head, her face brightening further as she kissed him.

He could tell she was as nervous as him, the way she trembled as they kissed, her breathing irregular, the way she flinched slightly as he placed a hand gently on her breast, though with her own hand now pressing against his hardness, there was no issue that he was going too far.

When they finally parted, breathless, Jonah felt his entire body on fire.

He said, “You ever do it in here? When you were dating?”

It was more of a nervous question, to fill the pause, than an honest need to know.

Like he was delaying things, giving her a chance to call it off. Giving him a chance to run away. He felt so unbelievably aroused, yet something about Lily’s wild past still terrified him.

Perhaps it was the sense that he had so much to compare against, considering all the men—and women—she’d been with before.

Perhaps it was because it had been a while since she’d been with a man.

She shook her head at his question, said, “This was always the family room, a safe place. We kept things confined to the bedroom.”

Jonah nodded, and then she whispered: “Come on, I’ll show you.”



Following her up the narrow flight of stairs, he felt like a teenager facing the prospect of losing his cherry.

Lily oozed sexuality, that was for sure. In every movement, in every expression, she just seemed to flow so gracefully, everything about her so very feminine.

As she’d kissed him, he’d been frightened that so much knowledge about her dating past would ruin things for him. There’d been girlfriends back in the early days of Oxford where he’d found out about previous boyfriends, and been put off. Yet now, as his gaze appreciated the firm roundness of her behind on the way upstairs, he actually felt a tickle of elation, that such a sensual, experienced woman was offering herself to him.

He felt a little shiver pass through him as she led him by the hand along past the door of the little office and onward into the bedroom.

This was where it all happened. Wild, unbridled depravity.

It looked so tidy, so perfectly composed, like the finished result from a TV home improvement show. Yet it had borne witness to things Jonah had only ever thought people did in porn movies. Men having sex with another man's wife while he watched. Men teaming up to penetrate the same girl at the same time.

Women exploring each other while taking it in turns to have a guy pound them.

God, did real people actually do that?

The world of other people's sex lives, into which the Internet now offered a window, could be insane.

"Julian would sit in this chair?" he asked her now, as though he was obligated to continue questioning her, even though they both knew why she'd really invited him into her bedroom.

"That's right," she said, pulling him in for another deep kiss, her arms locking around his neck. Between snatched kisses, she explained: "Sometimes he'd let me go on ahead... take our guest up here... get the preliminaries out of the way..."

"The preliminaries?" Jonah raised an eyebrow.

As if to indicate, Lily unfastened the remaining few buttons of her shirt, pulling it off to reveal her pale yet shapely torso, her toned stomach, her ample breasts in a plain black bra, chest heaving with need.

She reached for his shirt, pulling it up, over his head. "Sometimes he liked to see the whole thing," she said. "The women and the couples tended to expect it."

She grinned as she now fumbled with his belt, and he could tell she was beginning to really get off on shocking him, on exposing her degenerate secrets for the first time to someone not previously involved in them.

"Didn't I tell you there were sometimes couples?"

“I think you at least hinted at it,” he said, letting her drag his jeans and his underwear down his thighs to reveal his swollen manhood to her delighted gaze.

Dropping to her knees to help him step out of his remaining clothes, she looked up at him, her hands sweeping up to take hold of his hardness, and said, “I liked being with them. They made me feel that what Julian and I had... wasn’t so weird.”

Jonah groaned as she kissed the top of his cock, then slipped her tongue around it.

“Were any of them like you and your husband? One of them just wanting to watch?”

“No,” she said, running her fingers all over and around his cock, his sac, his loins, exploring him, reveling in his nudity. “But some of them had been with other couples who were.”

Lily had him perch on the edge of the bed, practically facing the chair where her husband used to sit. It felt strange, the ghosts of debauchery somehow lingering in the air, and Jonah found it hard to avoid thinking that other guys had sat exactly where he was sitting now, while this young wife took their cocks into her mouth in front of her husband.

“Was it weird between your husband and the other guy... when you were...

pleasuring him?”

“You mean was Julian ever freaked out when I sucked another guy’s cock in front of him?”

So well-spoken, so well brought up, the words seemed so filthy as they passed her lips.

“Maybe it was a little weird in the beginning,” she said, “but Julian didn’t really show it. Almost like he was just doing research.”

Jonah groaned again as she ran her tongue all the way up from the base of his cock to the tip, before taking his sensitive end in her hot mouth. She was just too elegant to have the grotesque form of a stiff cock between

her lips. It was a thrillingly decadent sight, perhaps even more so as she took it out again and stroked it all over her pretty face, moistening her cheeks with his pre-come.

She held back her hair and now sank her head down on his shaft, and Jonah thought he could almost understand how Julian could get off on the corruption of such an otherwise polished, sophisticated person.

There was something so dark and delicious about the idea of this stylish, poised woman being wickedly defiled.

With one hand gently cupping his sac, the other gripping his shaft, she began servicing him with her lips and tongue, and the scintillating heat of her contact made his cock throb inside her mouth.

No wonder Nate had a thing for married women.

Jonah stroked her soft hair and her cheek as she worked up a glorious rocking motion on his shaft. She was looking up at him, managing a smile even with her mouth so full, apparently enjoying her oral servicing of his hardness. He couldn't help but moan in response.

"You're quite gifted, Jonah," she said, breaking off, flashing him some of her pearly whites.

He said, "You're going to finish things rather abruptly if you keep that up."

"You shouldn't see it as finishing," she purred, but did slow her hand on his shaft, taking to licking him and kissing him, rather than fucking him with her

mouth. "If you do come, you should just see it as the transition to something else."

"Transition to something else?"

"Your attention on me," she breathed, and now pulled herself up slowly to stand between his knees, her hands sliding over her body as though she were making love to herself, her hips, chest, writhing and swaying as if to some unheard music.

She was dancing for him—slowly, sensually, her hands fondling her chest, even slipping her breasts out of her bra to play with her hard nipples. She gave him a twirl while sliding her hands on down her concave waist to flick the catch at her waist, and turning her back to him, revealing her shapely behind as she pulled down her slacks to expose a tiny little black thong.

“I was a shy wallflower before Julian decided to bring other people into our sex life,” she said.

“They taught you things?”

“They gave me confidence,” she smiled. “Confidence in the power I can have over men.”

Jonah had never had someone dance for him like this, so sexually sure of herself, playing with the little straps holding up the scrap of silk between her thighs, offering him a tantalizing glimpse here or there, then turning round to display the breathtaking form of her behind, so round and peachy. It was even a little intimidating how sexy she was, though he wasn’t complaining.

She said, “When we began using that website, I was so self conscious when it came to anything like this. I felt foolish, just wanted to turn out the lights, strip down in the dark.”

“And what did they teach you?” Jonah slipped his fingers into the waistband of her underwear, pulled her to him so he could kiss her stomach.

“To relax,” she said. “To slow down. That a man will find me desirable no matter what I do, but that moving slowly, flowing like this, it’ll drive him wild.”

“It drives me wild,” he said, breathing in the fresh floral scent from her skin until she broke away to give him another slow pirouette, flaunting her shapely derriere at him, then reach behind herself to release the catch on her bra.

“Confidence is half the battle,” Lily said, slipping her bra straps over her shoulder, but now leaning forward to use Jonah’s body to pull the bra

itself from her body. “Knowing that a man’s too aroused to laugh at you, that if you move nice... and slow... being sexy’s just a state of mind...”

Her breasts were round and full, her nipples engorged as she drew back a moment to play with them, hands kneading her flesh, fingers grazing her stiff buds, before she moved over him again, draping those soft globes over his body, caressing his stomach and his chest—and even his throbbing hardness—with her velvet curves.

She let him touch her, moaned as he cupped her breasts, coaxed her soft flesh, craned forward to take her nipples into his hot mouth.

Then she withdrew again, slowly twirled to present her pert behind, and slipped her panties down over her hips and thighs, to let the scrap of black silk drop to the floor.

Peering at him over a shoulder, she flashed him a grin as she caught the expression of unbridled lust plastered over his face and backed into him, bending to push her naked behind over his crotch, wiggling it a little as she edged back to touch down against his hard cock.

She lay back against him, still writhing in her slow dance, so that he could trail his hands all over her body, indulging in her exquisite curves, relishing the glorious softness of her skin, burying his face into her neck to inhale her vibrant, feminine scent.

“Before,” he said, “was it strange to have more than one person in the room?”

“At first,” she said, “and then it just seemed to give me more confidence.”

He felt the raw heat of her pussy as she ground it against his rigid shaft, and so badly wanted to just slip inside her. But she broke away again, turning to straddle his legs now, showing him the full, yet tidy dark triangle of hair over her mound.

Pressing her pussy up against his cock so he could feel how wet she was, she was only able to spend a moment or two over him before he suddenly grabbed her, and lifted her up onto the bed, to roll over her and gain the high ground, making her squeal and giggle in surprise.

“I’m not sure I’m as patient as you’re used to,” he said.

“Oh, I’m not used to anything any more,” she said, delighting in the way he now manhandled her, his muscles flexing to lift her and lay her out along the bed, his carnal need so clearly evident.

Yet for all his own need, Jonah now lay on his hardness, stifling it as he curled his arms around Lily’s milky thighs, pulling her pussy to his mouth, his desire to taste her superseding his need to penetrate her.

Lily caught her breath as he began nosing through the soft hair on her mound, breathing in the smoky, earthy scent of her arousal. He kissed the top of her sensitive folds, and ran his tongue through her hot, glistening lips, flushed burgundy with her desire.

She turned her head as she lay there, and let out a long sensual moan.

“Oh God...” she breathed, her chest heaving as his hands slipped up to hold those magnificent breasts as she thrust them up in response to him wedging his face into her soaking pussy.

Her hands moved from clasping her thighs to clasping his head as he continued to devour her, loving her flavor, loving the noises she made in response to him—

the little gasps, the low groans, the light whining as he sucked on her clit and slipped his fingers inside her, the sensations threatening to overcome her completely.

As he held her, his hands firmly grasping her buttocks to pull her to his mouth, she squirmed, almost trying to get relief from him, yet each time he loosened his grip, slowed his licking or sucking on her pussy, she merely pulled him into her again, pressing his face to her flesh to encourage him on.

He wasn’t sure how much more she could take, her whole body shaking, heaving, writhing, and finally turning over, to bury her face in the sheets, while pushing her behind up and lifting one leg out of his way, quite clearly to allow

him to continue accessing her soaking snatch.

It had been a while since she’d been with a man, and when Jonah finally took her to her full release, it was as powerful an orgasm as he’d ever

seen in a woman.

Collapsing on her back again, Lily was left panting, cursing, completely out of breath as Jonah gently stroked the soft hair around her sweet pussy, giving her the occasional kiss as she cooled down, his head leaning against her slender thigh, looking up at the exquisite sight of her undulating curves as she gradually got her breathing back under control.

“You are something else,” she laughed, once she was able to do so.

“You too,” he said, smiling, his face slick with her juices.

“You would definitely have been invited back.”

“Julian liked it when other people made you come in front of him?”

“Oh, he enjoyed it, I’m pretty sure,” she said, reaching down to stroke his hair affectionately as he absently dipped his index finger into her slick groove.

“But he must have been a little jealous?”

“He said he was, but he didn’t act like it. Always told me he got this little pain inside, even when he was only thinking about me being with someone else.”

“And yet he insisted on it?”

“He said the pain excited him, aroused him,” she said, and sighed. “I suppose before all that, our lives had steadily turned into this sleepy existence—I mean we loved each other to bits, but you know what they say about familiarity.”

“You’re saying he just wanted to break the routine?”

Lily shrugged. “He said it made him feel alive, for the first time in a long while.

He spent all day every day writing about dead people—or live people as if they were dead. He said he wanted to get back in touch with the world of the living again.”

Jonah picked himself up off the bed, and slowly took the two or three steps over to the armchair in the corner, to sit where Lily's husband had once sat, to watch her there stretched out on the bed. It was hard to imagine loving this beautiful creature, and sitting here in this chair as another man even made out with her, let alone putting his hands all over her, defiling her sweet pussy, shoving his penis inside her. Yet sitting there, seeing how beautiful she was, how graceful she was, Jonah thought he could understand the thrill of seeing her taken before him. The very wrongness of the situation, the taboo nature of a man giving up his woman, brought the kind of illicit excitement that vanilla sex once had, when he had first started experiencing it.

Lily began playing with herself, touching herself, her hands sweeping over her breasts, her stomach, her thighs, between her legs, and she was looking over at him as though trying to offer him a show, a glimpse of what it was like.

He tried to imagine Emma on the bed, what it might feel like to see her with someone else, and be unable to stop it. Or Mulray, for that matter. It wasn't quite like being married, he suspected, but the feelings were quite startling.

"You would need to be a masochist," he said, out loud, then suddenly worried he was insulting her dead husband. Was he calling himself a masochist, too, for being so curious about all this?

Lily simply smiled. "Maybe," she said. "You know the term was named for a man who shared his wife?"

He said, "How did you deal with it... when Julian was with other people?"

She shrugged as Jonah returned to the bed, sat by her. "I guess I felt a little pain as well, to start with, but after so many months of coldness between Julian and I..."

"You just needed the attention," Jonah said, leaning down to kiss her pussy briefly, to sample her flavor once more. Then he said, "Was he... cold? Julian, I mean."

Lily patted the bed, urging Jonah to come lie by her, and now reached over to the top drawer of her bedside table.

“I think he always could be a little on the cold side,” she said. “That’s not to say

he wasn’t loving and affectionate—”

“Of course not,” Jonah said, feeling a quiet excitement building inside him as Lily produced a condom, and now leaned over him, her silky hair trailing over his thighs as she licked and sucked him back up to full hardness before rolling the latex sheath down his length.

“He could be quite clinical at times,” Lily said now, as she straddled his thighs, shuffling slowly up to rest the heat of her pussy against his erect cock. “Initially when we were dating I saw it as his raw intelligence, and I found it quite sexy.”

“And when you were engaged in your bedroom scenes?”

She shrugged, “I saw it as part of his self-protection mechanism.”

Jonah groaned, and Lily bit her bottom lip as she now slipped the tip of his cock inside her pussy, and then slowly sank down on his hardness. He could feel her swollen pussy tight around his rigid flesh, but while he reached for her breasts, she kept back, taunting him with a devilish grin, allowing only the contact between her pussy and his cock.

Jonah shuffled and tensed seemingly every muscle in his body, and made her squeal again as he now lifted her body, so he could slide his feet under himself and somehow kneel up.

It was a little more athletic than he was used to, but perhaps something about her being experienced, or just the way her elegant form and the whiff of her piquant scent seemed to drive him on, inspired him to more than he’d thought he was able.

Lily put her arms around his neck and kissed him, seeming a little surprised his change of position had succeeded without loss of penetration, and while she now bounced on his hardness, emitting shrill little cries as she did so, Jonah held her around the waist and up her back and shoulders, squeezing his thighs to match her movement. It seemed

every muscle in both of their bodies was required as they moved together, and Jonah wondered how long he could manage it before he collapsed.

She was so beautiful writhing against him, occasionally leaning away from him, arching her back to leave him simply holding her hips as he continued thrusting

inside her, the blood rushing into her head as they fucked, Jonah getting a spectacular view of her breasts stretched and peaked by her hard nipples.

At last, she pulled him down like a hungry lioness, so that for a while she could mount him, cowgirl style, riding him for all he was worth, before she too seemed to tire, and instead lay beside him, spooning into him, Jonah sliding his hardness back inside her, but their bodies now able to move slowly, leisurely, making the most of their contact together.

“You will stay the night?”

“If you want me to,” he replied quietly, his mouth close to her ear.

She smiled, “It’s something that never happened with Julian. A person could do almost anything to my body, but they never got to spend the night.”

“I feel honored.”

She turned, and pushed herself up onto all fours. “You want some?” she grinned.

Somehow, seeing Lily like that, tilting her cute butt up for him, Jonah felt a fresh burst of energy and arousal. Picking himself up, he knelt behind her shapely rear, carefully guiding his latex-sheathed cock into her tight channel.

Inside her, he leaned over her and pulled her close to him, so they were actually both almost sitting up, Jonah able to fondle her breasts and reach around to massage her clit as he stirred his hard cock within her.

He loved to hear her moan, and the way her body writhed as he moved inside her, the way she blushed from the exertion. She was so exquisitely sensual. He kissed the back of her neck, slowly, breathing in her fragrant

perfume that blended with the sweet underlying aroma that was her individual scent.

How could Julian have given this away? How could he find sexual pleasure in the pain of seeing other men having their way with her?

The questions whirling around his head brought Jonah back to the strange fact that in the months before he died, Julian may have actively started pursuing other women again, yet leaving this beautiful woman at home, in the dark.

Still moving inside her, Jonah said, "What made you think Julian was using a dating website again? I mean just before he died."

Lily smiled, and now slumped down, so she was lying flatter on the bed, though without breaking Jonah's penetration, his cock still forcing its way into her smoldering pussy from behind.

"Do you always like to interrogate a girl while you're fucking her?" she asked, breathless.

"I'm sorry," he said with a grin, "I guess I just worry if I don't ask a question, it'll slip out of my mind."

But she wasn't angry at him. She said, "You know, you can always come back if you have more questions. In fact, I wonder if I shouldn't start keeping a few things back, so you have to come back."

"I'll come back," he said.

She nodded, but before she answered him, she pulled herself out from under him, then wrestled him over to straddle him once more.

"Julian was a good father," she said, drawing out a small gasp from Jonah as she forcefully sat on his cock, her pussy squeezing him so tight he thought she must be as close to another orgasm as he was. "I honestly think in the first two years of Aaron's life, he was so engrossed in helping with the care duties he hardly thought about sex."

"But then he started thinking about it?"

“He seemed to want it a little more, but I was still just so tired most of the time, I guess I pushed him away,” she said.

Lily was moving slowly on top of him, and for this he was thankful, feeling it increasingly difficult to hold himself back from finishing.

“And were there actually any signs he was dating again?”

“There were a few evenings here or there where drinks after work dragged on until the small hours,” she said. “I didn’t think much of it most of the time. Once

or twice he came home smelling as though he’d showered recently, and I think that made me suspicious. Most of those times I was asleep by the time he got home, though.”

“Did you ask him about it?”

“I didn’t really have the energy. Plus, after what we’d done before Aaron came along, I could hardly denounce him for cheating, could I?”

“You would have at least deserved honesty.”

“I just didn’t think it was worth the bad blood between us. Perhaps part of me thought once I was ready, I’d be able to join him,” she said. “I didn’t want to push him away from me. This was what brought us closer together before, I assumed it could again.”

“And—”

Lily put a finger to his mouth, said, “You’re a funny one, Jonah Fielding. I think I’m going to have to shut you up just so we can both come.”

Jonah chuckled, but said, “Just one more question.”

She flashed her eyes at him, and now hopped up to turn herself around. “One question.”

“Did you ever happen to see what username and password Julian used when you guys were using the website, back in the old days?”

She leaned down now, to remove the condom from Jonah's cock, and her cute derriere shuffled closer to his face so that he could smell the ripe scent of her soaking sex.

"Sure," she said, kissing the tip of his cock gently. "He tended to use the same password for all his computer stuff."

"And you wouldn't mind telling me?"

"That's two questions," Lily chided him, and now silenced him by clamping her hot, wet pussy firmly down over his mouth.

It wasn't long before she was coming again, and he was able to let go, and fill her mouth with his seed.

Six

When he prized himself out of bed in the morning, she was still fast asleep. He left her that way—let her lie in, since she wasn't due to collect Aaron until 10am.

They both needed the rest considering the lateness of the hour when they'd finally drifted off to sleep. But Jonah felt obligated to get up and out. Things to do, people to see.

Outside, there was a chill in the air but the sun was shining, and the brightness seemed appropriate for the new sense of hope that enlivened Jonah's blood. The dull throb of physical contentment continued to course around his system from a wonderful night with Lily, and that would probably have made him feel good all on its own. But he also felt a sense of achievement—that for perhaps the first time, his amateurish investigation might actually have turned up something of use.

He wasn't entirely surprised to find a welcoming committee waiting for him out on the street, in the form of DI Mulray. She was once again parked across the street from the house, standing there in her inexpensive but smart suit, leaning against her little unmarked Ford with her arms folded expectantly.

"And how do you like your eggs in the morning?"

“You can’t possibly complain, Detective,” he said as he descended the steps from Lily’s front door down to street level. “You were the one that suggested me as a service contractor.”

She shrugged, and Jonah felt a slight feeling of disappointment that she did actually seem okay about his sleeping with Lily, as though that ruled out any interest she might have for him.

“Oh, I’m not complaining,” she said. “I hope it was useful, though.”

“It was, as it happens.”

“D’you need a lift somewhere?” she asked.

“That would be nice. Give me a chance to tell you Julian Foster’s user name and password for that dating website.”



Mulray dropped him off at the door of his building, showing off her ability to drive on the pedestrianized quayside, since she was driving a police vehicle.

Even if she did not mean it consciously, it was a nod to the power of her badge at a time when she was trying to persuade him to bring his own personal investigation into his brother’s death to a halt.

“You’ve done your part,” she was saying as they crawled along tiles meant only for walking, heading towards the base of the glass-fronted tower, 1 West India Quay. “You’ve shown us that it’s worth investigating this website, and whether it’s linked to these killings. Now leave the rest to us.”

Jonah didn’t want to lie to the beautiful dark-haired detective and tell her he’d stop pursuing the killer, but he really didn’t want to comply with her demand to stop, either.

She looked at him a moment, switching off the engine once they’d drawn up outside the building front door. “It’s dangerous, you know that?” she

said, and her genuine concern warmed Jonah a little, stirring up his crush on her, though he knew he could not have her.

“I know.”

“If what you’re saying about that website is true, then your use of it puts you right in the firing line for the Black Widow.”

“I’d hope so,” he said, his tone sounding brave, though in reality it was only so relaxed because he was accepting that DI Mulray was out of his reach, would forever remain merely a crush.

“Well, at least promise me one thing,” she said.

“What would that be?”

“Don’t go looking into Julian Foster’s account on that website.”

Jonah felt crushed. That was his only lead with any real potential.

Before he could answer, Mulray said quietly: “You realize as soon as I give that

username and password to our IT team, they’ll be all over it like a rash?”

“I’d hope so.”

“But if you access that account, best case scenario you would just throw up a load of rogue evidence that somebody would have to spend time looking into,”

she said. “Worst case? Some try-hard DI would link you to Julian Foster, and even if you weren’t suspected of murder, you might be charged with obstructing justice.”

Jonah nodded. The implication, of course, was also there that if Jonah was charged with obstructing justice, Mulray herself could be disciplined for knowing about his meddling, and perhaps even for encouraging it, although her actions had been necessary to uncover the details of Julian Foster’s website account.

He paused, not quite knowing what to say.

Mulray said softly: “Just give us a little time. If our detectives can’t find anything through that account, maybe they’ll be open to someone else taking a look...”

“I doubt that,” he said, feeling defeated, frustrated, but finding it hard to be angry at Mulray for the pure logic of her request.

“I’ll see what I can do—I’ll see if there’s any information I can get hold of from the account,” she said, genuine concern in her face, and also perhaps a hint of appreciation that he was actively trying to assist the investigation.

Jonah nodded, accepting her deal.

He joked: “Hey, if you want my help getting information out of any of the other victims’ wives, you just let me know.”

“I might take you up on that offer, you know,” she smiled. Then her attention was distracted. “Hey, who’s the blonde?”

Jonah looked over to where she was looking, and could see Emma leaning against the wall by the door of his building, looking a trifle annoyed until she caught sight of him in the car, whereupon her whole demeanor brightened into a

pretty smile.

“A friend,” he said, trying not to visibly react to Emma’s exceedingly short black skirt, which appeared to be made of netting or some kind, showing plenty of smooth thigh.

Nevertheless, Mulray raised her eyebrows suggestively.

Now it was Jonah’s turn to sigh, thinking that she must think him the worst kind of rogue, though up until he’d started using the No Strings website, he’d been the next best thing to a monk.

“She’s just helping me figure all this out,” he said, then realized that particular explanation might refer to all manner of seedy things. He had to concede, however, that he had done all manner of seedy things recently. Probably not good for his crush to find out.

He said, “She’s helping me with my... research.”

“Helping you meddle,” Mulray nodded, her judgmental tone appearing to be reserved more for his attempt at getting involved in the murder investigation than his associating with blondes in short skirts.

Jonah reached for the handle to open the car door, and as he pulled it, Mulray said, “Well, just be careful, Jonah, if you are going to continue with that website.”

He paused, more than a little taken by her use of his Christian name.

“I can do that much,” he said, offering her a parting smile before hauling himself out of the vehicle.



Emma hesitated a moment as Mulray drove slowly away, as though she was afraid she’d interrupted something. Then as Jonah turned to her, she suddenly rushed him, throwing herself at him as though it had been forever since she’d seen him. It had been a few days, sure enough, but still.

She said, “I’ve been calling you and texting—what the hell, Mister?”

Jonah hugged her back, but slipped his hand in his pocket to retrieve his phone, which appeared to have long since run past its battery life. He showed her the dead piece of plastic, and she gave him a playful swat on the cheek.

“You have to keep in closer contact,” she said, now taking him by the hand to lead him inside the building. “What if you got in trouble, one of your dates turned out to actually be the killer?”

“I suppose so,” he nodded, suitably chastised.

There was a cool early morning breeze blowing in off the river, and Jonah now ushered them inside to shelter from it. He was feeling seriously tired after the night’s activity.

“Who was she? From the website?” Emma asked. “She’s pretty.”

The young blonde led the way inside, past a concierge who seemed to find it difficult to cover up his interest in Emma’s short skirt, and into the elevator.

“Police detective. I was... helping her, you know, answering a few questions about the case.”

“And she gave you a lift home personally? Very nice,” Emma’s eyes flashed, but now the elevator doors opened, and Jonah simply stepped past her, inside.

“What are you even doing here this time of day?” Jonah demanded as they ascended to the 22 nd floor. “I thought you were a student.”

“What makes you think I’m a student?” she gave him a look of mock-offense.

“I guess I just got that impression when you were with your friends in the bar the

other night.”

She shrugged, “Well, I am a student. But we students don’t sleep into the afternoons these days, you know, even at weekends. Not now we have to pay so much for tuition.”

Jonah chuckled, “For some reason I can’t picture you as a bookworm.”

Having already been surprised at her appearance so early on a Saturday morning, Jonah was doubly surprised on the way up to the apartment when she announced that she’d lined up a lunch meeting for him for that day.

“You did want some help speeding up your dating process, right?”

“Right. But a lunch meeting?”

In truth, Jonah was still a little impressed that Emma had been serious about being his personal assistant on this bizarre quest for justice. What

was her motivation? That it was fun to track down one night stands for him?

“You said you wanted married women,” she said as they reached the 22nd floor.

“I have found you married women—but this one wants a lunch date first.”

Jonah paused before entering the code on the keypad to open the front door to Nate’s flat, and Emma noticed his hesitation. She said, “You are still under the impression that Nate had a preference for married—”

“I am,” he interrupted her, and now tapped in the code. “I just don’t much like the idea of actually... you know... getting involved in someone’s marriage.”

Emma said, “They’re the ones making the decision to step outside their marriage, you know. Nothing to do with you.”

“I suppose.”

“But you don’t have to worry about all that this time.”

“And how is that?”

“Because this one says her husband wants her to sleep with other men.”

“Kinky.” Jonah felt his ears burn—this was just like Julian and Lily. Was this whole consensual infidelity thing that common? Jonah felt that it needed further investigation—if Nate did indeed have a preference for married women, there was a chance he’d been party to this kind of kink.

Jonah hung his jacket on the coat stand as Emma dumped her backpack on one of the white couches, and felt instantly more relaxed being back in Nate’s apartment. He was going to miss this place when that useless estate agent finally got it sold. He picked up one of the TV remotes from the coffee table between the white couches, and flipped on Nate’s huge television, which emerged as if by magic from the large cabinet in the corner of the apartment. As ever, the set was tuned to the rolling 24-hour BBC News channel.

“Nothing new on the news,” Emma said.

Jonah nodded. There was footage of continuing violence in Palestine on the news, and when he switched to CNN, or Sky News, it was just more of the same.

“I guess Martin Sallow fell off the news cycle,” she said.

“He’ll be back on it. Police haven’t said anything much since he was found, yet.”

“So what happened with you last night? You gonna tell me?” she asked him, sidling up to him, slinging her arms around him, pressing her nose to his cheek to breathe in his scent.

For her part, the pretty blonde swamped his senses with her cloud of coconut-scented perfume, and Jonah couldn’t help but be affected by her.

“Oh, right,” he said. “Last night.”

When her hand slipped down his body and found its way between his legs, he was already hard. He wondered if he should keep Lily’s secrets to himself, but if Emma was going to help him on this investigation, there was no point in keeping her in the dark about anything.

“I met Lily Foster, the widow of—”

“Julian, right. You said you were meeting her.”

When he turned to her, away from the television, he found she’d already removed her skirt. If he wasn’t fully hard before, he was to see her in those little turquoise lace panties. She was so different to Lily—and yet just as sexy in her own, bright and breezy way.

“And did she tell you her husband was using the same website as Nate?”

He kissed her, and now peeled her little white tank top from her body, over her head to reveal her pert little breasts bound in a bra that matched her panties.

“Pretty much. She said she had a strong feeling he was,” he told her. “At least recently.”

“So why didn’t she tell the police?”

“She’s a journalist. She’s worried the story’ll get leaked to the press, and that will be the end of her reputation.”

“Her reputation?”

“They both used to use the website—or one just like it—together. A few years ago.”

“If they both used it—did she still have access to his account?”

“I don’t know. She’s given me the usual username and password he used.”

“But he was doing it without her recently, if she didn’t know about it. So that password might not work.”

Jonah shifted to make room for her on the bed. “Maybe, maybe not. I had to promise that detective I wouldn’t try it out.”

“You did what?”

He shrugged. “She said the police would now be crawling all over it—if I went snooping around in there, they’d spot my IP address, or the IP address where I accessed it. Even if they didn’t think I was connected to the crime, she said it could still mess up the evidence if I try.”

“That sucks. Could have told us a load of stuff to help our search.”

Jonah smiled at her use of the word “our”. It seemed that he hardly knew Emma, but with precious few friends in London, it was nice to have company—and a little assistance on his search for Nate’s killer was wonderful.

She kissed him again, her hands pulling on his shirt buttons. “Was she good?”

“Good?”

“You spent the night,” she smiled at him knowingly. “And I can tell she wears Chanel.”

It seemed funny to him, that she wasn't displeased he'd just been with another woman. She wanted to indulge in his experience as much as she wanted him to now tend to her needs. Kind of sexy, though, that she wanted to know.

"She hadn't been with anyone since it all happened."

"So you were fulfilling a need?" With his shirt off, now Emma's hands fell to his belt. Jonah, for his part was able to reach around and unfasten her bra, revealing her nipples, stiff in the chilled air. Yet the way she went about it, he was naked before she was.

"Tell me how it was," she said, her fingers curling around his hardness, the expression on her face looking as though it was Christmas morning and she'd just unwrapped a wonderful present.

"She told me what it was like when Julian invited other men into their bed."

"He invited other men? He swung both ways?"

Jonah slipped his fingers under the waistband of her panties, feeling the glorious softness of her skin, skirting through the little triangular dusting of her golden hair, and ultimately finding the hot groove of her sex, already seriously wet.

"The men weren't for him," he explained, tasting her sweet mouth again. "He liked to watch her with them."

Emma moaned, and it wasn't clear whether it was because he had slipped his

fingers gently inside her, or because she found the idea of a husband watching his wife with other men arousing.

"Mmm.... So maybe this lunch date I have for you will prove interesting," she purred, and now stepped back from him, her hands grabbing his to pull him away from the television, away from the couches.

"You're pretty good at all this. Organizing things, I mean."

She smiled. “Maybe I want to be a personal assistant when I’m done getting a degree,” she said.

“An actual personal assistant?”

She laughed, and broke away from him to turn and walk purposefully toward the bedroom, “It’s one option for bagging a rich husband, you know.”

Now it was Jonah’s turn to laugh. “Well I assume you won’t be hanging around me for long, then.”

“For you, I’ll make an exception,” she said, turning back to him with fire in her eyes as she slipped her panties down her thighs, allowing them to drop to the floor. “Especially the way you make me feel with that tongue of yours.”

Seven

“So how does this get me closer to the murderer again?” he asked, as they walked out across the cobbled piazza of Covent Garden.

It was just gone 12.30pm, and thankfully the day had warmed up a little. The sun had broken through the overcast sky, and now bathed the tourists and market traders in a beneficial light.

“You wanted married women, didn’t you? I got you a married woman.”

He rolled his eyes. “A woman who wants to meet with a guy for lunch first, before she decides on a date—how is she the Black Widow?”

“Maybe she’s just playing a role,” Emma said. “Getting you off guard. Getting you to trust her so you’ll let your guard down—and then she strikes.”

“I suppose so. I can always say ‘no’ to her. If it all seems pointless.”

“So then. Plus—don’t you think it’s exciting? Something different.” Emma gave him a wink, and he wasn’t sure what aspect of it was exciting to her.

But then it was up to him to go on ahead. He walked up the stairs, having never even known there was a second floor to the Covent Garden market. Yet here it was, and a strangely elegant restaurant it housed, too. A concierge took his jacket and passed him on to a young waitress who escorted him out onto a terrace overlooking the piazza.

There was a lone female sitting at a table nicely apart from others—not that there were many diners in here at this time.

She was young—seemed too young to be married and already looking for extramarital excitement. Perhaps 23 or 24 at most. Pretty. Blue eyes, girlish freckles. Her dirty-blonde hair was tied back in a loose but high ponytail that gave her an air of confidence, with bangs draping over her forehead to be tucked behind her ears.

She was wearing a sleeveless white blouse that perhaps revealed a little more pale flesh than she was used to showing.

It seemed clear to Jonah she was not as confident as her appearance on the surface might have suggested. Her eyes gave away her anxiety.

“Hello,” he said. “I’m Robert.”

“Uh... hi. Bethany.”

She stood, and reached out to offer him an awkward hand to shake. Not knowing how formal to be. Jonah was slightly amused—this was a lunch date where the possibility of sleeping with this young woman was on the table. And she was shaking his hand as a greeting? Well, he didn’t need to go through with this particular encounter. He felt it wasn’t going to add much to the investigation.

It would have been rude to skip the lunch, though.

Knowing this was just lunch, nothing more, actually made him relax. She was pretty in a very girl-next-door kind of way, fresh, well-spoken. And her nervousness endeared her to him.

There was no need for any of this. It took a certain amount of the pressure off Jonah. But, as it turned out, she had an interesting story to tell, particularly in light of what he’d learned about Lily and Julian Foster.

Bethany had only recently learned of her husband Ritchie's fantasies, that he imagined her sleeping with other men. It had shocked her massively, stumbling over his Internet browser history, finding all the erotic stories he'd been reading about guys sharing their wives.

"You know, we've been together since we were 16. Never been with anyone else. I thought I knew him better than he knew himself," she sighed, flashing a self-deprecating smile. She had a faint blush in her cheeks at talking about all this, which only enhanced her beauty.

"Everyone has their secrets," Jonah said, feeling the need to reassure her.

She nodded. It seemed she had a lot to get off her chest—but with something difficult like this, it was hardly something you could talk about with friends or

family. Jonah was probably the first person she'd spoken with about any of this, other than her husband. Jonah suddenly felt a responsibility towards her wellbeing.

"I guess things cooled off for us in the bedroom," she said. "You know how it is

—familiarity makes it all seem routine, and then add in a little stress at work, family commitments—we were too tired, like, all the time. And it just kind of faded."

"It happens a lot. Nothing out of the ordinary."

"You're not married?"

"No, I'm not. But I know of people in your situation." Not 23 or 24, though, he thought.

Bethany nodded again, reassured. "I mean, I've thought about other men, you know, every now and then. But it's just fantasy, isn't it? Like Twilight, or the Vampire Diaries, or Jace from the Mortal Instrument books. They're just make-believe. And I guess there were a couple of guys I might have imagined being with, you know. Fantasy. Particularly when it seemed like Richie wasn't interested.

“And then I discover this fantasy of his—and it kind of blew me out of the water, you know? I mean he wants me to have sex with another man. Wow.”

“It’s not something society really talks about,” Jonah said. “Women aren’t supposed to sleep around—and husbands aren’t supposed to allow their wives to sleep around.”

“No. But I see women at work in boring marriages, or the ones going through messy divorce cases, and I think how unhappy I am that we don’t have sex much at all any more, either. And I think—that could actually be me, you know?”

“But your husband is different.”

“He is. But it doesn’t make any sense.”

Bethany paused as the waiter came over to take their order, and Jonah realized he’d been riveted to the spot by her tale. It was fascinating, as it had been with

Lily. Hearing about unconventional relationships—maybe it interested the biologist part of him, the academic day job he’d been seriously neglecting ever since Nate died.

He ordered a glass of red wine—well, he didn’t have work to worry about—and a plate of lasagne. Bethany ordered an apple juice and a caesar salad.

As soon as the coast was clear again, she continued: “At first, I thought he was just suggesting this so I’d eventually let him have a threesome or something with another woman. But he said he’s not interested in other women.”

Jonah nodded. “There are guys who just get off on watching their loved ones taking pleasure in the arms of other people,” he said. “But they remain completely monogamous themselves.”

“It just seems completely crazy,” Bethany said, her forehead wrinkling up.

“But you are now contemplating... trying it out?” Jonah asked.

“I want to make him happy,” she said. “And if this is his burning fantasy, I want to see if this is really what he wants to do in reality.”

The waiter returned with their drinks, and in an attempt to present a perfectly ordinary picture of a first lunch date to the waiter, Jonah asked her about her job.

She worked at a law firm in the City as a paralegal, as it happened. The waiter didn’t seem bothered to listen in on the conversation.

“We talked a lot,” she said as the waiter withdrew, “and I did a lot of reading on the Internet. There really are a lot of guys like this, you know.”

“I’ve heard.”

“It’s just weird—that he might get just as much sexual satisfaction from my encounters with other men as I do myself. And want me even more afterwards.”

Jonah saw her blush deepen. He suspected she was open to the idea of sleeping with other men, if only her own guilt could be assuaged.

“You probably just need to take it really slowly,” he advised her. “Baby steps.

Make a little move forward—and then see if he’s still happy about it all. Then

you can afford to take another step forward. Don’t jump in with two feet, straight into an affair.”

Bethany nodded, and sighed, and seemed even to relax a little. Her eyes flickered as they trailed around his face, shuffled down to attempt a subtle assessment of his figure. The standard online dating review of the goods, he’d seen it all before.

She said, “That’s exactly what I want to do—but finding a guy who can be patient with me... well.”

She shifted in her seat, and he realized he could see the hint of white lace that was part of her bra, just visible where her neckline dipped.

She was a cute young woman, that was for sure. Pixieish, a touch willowy, perhaps, but so sweet.

“I’m sure any guy would be delighted to be patient with you,” he said warmly, then as her face betrayed her timid curiosity, he added: “if you were interested in seeing me again, I’d certainly be only too happy to take as much time as you’d like.”

So much for saying ‘no’ to her. His heart filled with pity for her—he wanted to take care of her, take her under his wing. Help her. Even if it was no help for the investigation.

“Thank you,” she said. “I... I’m afraid I don’t even have any experience of online dating or anything.”

Jonah smiled. “I’ve not been doing it long myself. You get used to it.”

She nodded.

“Do you know what kind of thing your husband is interested in?” he asked her.

“How d’you mean?”

“Well, has he said anything about whether his fantasy involves you going off and meeting guys alone, without him involved, or if he wants to be there, to watch you?”

“I... I’m not sure. I guess maybe he would want to watch.”

“And what would you prefer?”

“I don’t know... I guess I’d feel less guilty if he was there. If I could see this was what he wanted me to do. Does it freak you out, the thought of my husband being there?”

“No,” Jonah said, only in reality, he had no idea. Would he be able to perform in the presence of an audience? A male audience, the husband, at that. “But I guess you’ve got to find out what works for you. Is he watching right now?”

Jonah glanced around the restaurant, spotted Emma sitting on her own by the bar, but no other obvious lurkers observing their table.

“No. I’m just out on my lunch break,” she said. “He knows I’m doing this today

—but he trusts me.”

“That’s good. It’s all about trust.”

“He said whatever happens is my choice, I’m in control.”

The waiter brought their food. Jonah’s lasagne was light, Italian rather than English lasagne, with very little meat. Bethany’s salad was also fairly light.

“And what did you say to him?”

She smiled, “That today, I just wanted to meet you. See if we have chemistry, if I might want to take things further.”

“And?”

“I think I do—if you’re interested.”

“Of course.”

They ate relatively quickly, Jonah finding that after being so open and candid with Lily, he actually wanted to get back into the swing of being ‘Robert’ again, his City-boy persona. As they talked about life and trivial things while finishing up their light lunches, he wove stories about his City life, the vacuous existence

that saw him looking for cheap thrills by going on one night stands and the occasional longer-term fling.

“So why did you pick me for this?” he asked her. “Out of all the men on that website. Must have been dozens interested. Hundreds.”

“Richie picked you,” she said. “Or at least, he picked a few, and I decided on you out of the five he said he’d be okay with.”

“So why me?”

“You’re good-looking,” she blushed again. “Richie said the guys he’d picked out were less threatening to him.”

“How d’you mean, less threatening?”

She finished chewing on a piece of lettuce, then said, “We had a big row when he first told me about this. I mean—I was shocked. I thought he wanted out of the marriage, he didn’t love me any more. I thought maybe even that he was having an affair himself, and this was him trying to either justify it, or break up with me to go off with someone else. But then I told him to give me time, and leave me with his laptop, and I looked at what had been getting him off, what he’d been reading, at the pictures he looked at.”

Jonah said. “You’re quite the detective.”

She smiled. “It was kind of fun, actually. Seeing things he liked, things that turned him on but that he could never tell me about before, for whatever reason.

It was quite shocking, I guess, but the stories he read, the videos he downloaded

—there was quite a clear theme to them.”

“It made you feel better, seeing them?”

She shrugged. “I felt I understood him. The stories especially—explained a little of the psychology behind this. I guess after a while, it made me happier—he really was interested in the stories where the husband is monogamous, he just gets off on his wife’s pleasure, his wife playing with new guys. But there was definitely a thing about the new guys—they were not the kind of guys looking to take the wife away from her husband, or form any kind of romantic bond.”

“He doesn’t want you to fall for someone else.”

“No, just have sex with them. I think the guys he chose were ones who are really up for no-strings sex, you know? I guess you’re this big City trader, so there’s this stereotype that you sleep with a lot of women...”

“I suppose that’s probably true enough,” Jonah said, playing up to her need for reassurance. “Most women don’t like to hear about it, though. You know, I have another date tonight?”

“You do? With someone like me?”

“A little different.”

“Married?”

“I think so.”

“You like married women?”

“They’re usually the hottest ones,” he chuckled to conceal his bluff, his suggestion he’d been with plenty of married women. “They’re so keen, so sexual. So beautiful.”

She smiled, looked down demurely. When she looked up again, straight in his eyes, she looked quite serious, said, “Do you think my marriage is going to crumble, Robert?”

He shook his head. “As long as you communicate—every step of the way —

you’ll be okay. Don’t keep anything from him—what you do, what you talk about, what you even think when you’re not with him.”

“Right.”

“Because the thrill for him is knowing what’s going on, that you’re being so sexual, and that it’s making you feel great.” Jonah was impressed at how expert he seemed after one night with Lily Foster. His advice just spewed forth as he imagined what it might have been like for Julian to cope with Lily’s sharing.

Would he really be able to cope if he had a wife as lovely as Bethany, and she

was with another man?

Then Jonah added: “And the most important thing is to enjoy yourself—if you’re not, your husband’s fantasy collapses.”

“I guess so,” she laughed, a pretty soprano laugh.

“And then when you return to your husband, make sure you show him a lot of attention—tell him everything, and make him your lover again.”

At the end of the meal, Jonah escorted her out of the restaurant, past Emma and down the stairs to ground level. Then she gave him that awkward look again, not sure how to leave things.

She said, “Would you mind if... if I kissed you?”

Jonah felt a slight tingle in his nether regions. She really did look so pretty with that gentle blush.

“Course not,” he said softly, and stepped closer to her, breathing in a chestful of vanilla.

Being fairly petite, she had to stretch up, but then her mouth was on his, her arms pulling her tight against him, her lips so sweet. Tentative, nervous to start with, and then she relaxed as he gave her space, allowed her to lead, let her gently suck on his lips, delve the tip of her tongue in his mouth.

Her hands went to his head, pulling him to her, the passion beginning to flow—

they definitely had chemistry.

It was when her eyes flicked to the side briefly, quite obviously checking something out some distance away, that Jonah realized her husband, Richie, had to have been watching them. He might not have been in the restaurant observing their meal, but he’d seen the kiss. Jonah found himself curious as to how Richie felt about this.

“Oh, my,” she said, gazing in his eyes and beaming broadly at him as they finally broke apart.

“You think he’s going to be okay with this?” Jonah asked her.

“Yes, I do. But I’ll be in touch.” Then, as she backed up to begin walking over towards the Jubilee Market Hall, where presumably her husband was waiting for her in among the market stalls where he could not be detected, she said, “Nice meeting you, Robert!”

Eight

“Aren’t you supposed to go that way?”

“Which way?”

“You know, down the face.”

Jonah was leaning over the sink in the bathroom, dragging a razor up under his jaw, as Emma sat herself down on the toilet beside him.

“Are you saying you know better than a guy how to shave a guy’s face?”
Jonah laughed.

“So did I do good? Trying you out with Bethany?”

He nodded. “It was a little strange—you know, talking to her about maybe having sex some time, and her husband is going to know about all of it.”

“Kinda hot,” Emma said, leaning back against the cistern, trailing her fingers along the insides of her thighs. “So you think you’ll do it? Even if he wants to watch?”

“I might,” he said. “I mean, I feel like I want to help them. And if Nate did have a thing for married women, I like to think he’d go for this kind of set-up. I think I’ll learn a few things with Bethany.”

Emma blurted out: “You don’t shave like that! I have brothers—I’ve seen them do it.”

“Gives you a closer shave this way.”

“Seriously. Why would you need such a close shave? It’s already late. Not like you’re going to get five o’clock shadow.” She looked blank a moment, as though distracted by the bulge he presented under the towel hanging from his waist.

Then she looked up at him, a glimmer of mild shock flickering through her eyes

before she said, “Oh.”

He paused mid-stroke, razor just hanging there, and he glanced down to see if she was quietly judging him. She wasn’t—her eyes seemed glazed as she looked off into some imagined distance, dreaming, biting her lip distractedly. She looked cute, imagining the reasons for his extra close shave, sitting there in her white-and-navy patterned tank top and crimson satin panties—but he had to keep his focus away from her for now.

“Did she tell you to?” she asked as he resumed shaving.

“No. She doesn’t tell me a lot, actually.”

“But she’s a dominatrix?”

“She dominates. I’m not sure if she’s a dominatrix. I don’t think I’ve ever really met one of those.”

Emma lifted her arm, her hand reaching for his bulge, fingers splaying out over the towel to trace out his shape.

“So you’re just doing it unasked? Just in case. You really want to impress her, huh?”

“Jealous?” he chuckled, though he knew she wasn’t. She couldn’t be, the amount of help she was giving him setting up more Internet dates.

“You wish,” she joked, and part of him was a touch sad that she wasn’t. Emma was a catch, but he’d come to accept that she was too young for anything serious. She was just enjoying life, enjoying a wild ride. She said, “You think she’ll want to do it in the car park again?”

“I don’t know. Maybe. She’s asked me to meet her at the same restaurant as last time.”

She was stroking him through the towel, and it felt nice, only improved by the sight of her left knee drifting up, exposing her panties a little more to his occasional glances. Only, then as he was doing the fiddly bits

around his nose, he felt her little hands tucking into his waistband, pulling open the towel, freeing it up to drop to the floor.

“Hey,” he said sharply, as her hands now went to his bare, semi-hard cock. “I’m supposed to meet her in, like, 20 minutes. You want to spoil it all?”

He saw her lick her lips.

She said, “You didn’t need it last time, did you? You said you just ate her pussy and then she drove away.”

“Yeah, but this is the second date. Maybe it’ll go further.”

“What, like your murder?”

“I can handle myself.”

Emma sighed. “You really haven’t thought it through, Jonah,” she said, her voice sharp, deadly serious for the first time he could remember, and in the mirror her expression was similarly grave. “I mean: it’s been fun, right? Playing the detective, fooling around, meeting some hot babes to bang... but you know, this could really get dangerous, right?”

“I’m counting on it.” Jonah felt the ripple of anxiety, and knew there was a lot to what she was saying.

“And what makes you think that if the Black Widow does eventually turn up, you’ll be able to deal with her when your brother couldn’t?”

Jonah felt hollow inside. Was he doing the right thing? What if she did suddenly appear—was he going to talk his way into a position to capture her, kill her? It was stupid.

“I have to do something,” he said quietly. Then he had a thought. “You know, even beyond your kinky little need to check out my date, that actually might be the safest strategy.”

“What d’you mean? I don’t get it.”

“Well, if we could swing it so you can subtly observe my date when I meet her—

even take pictures if you've got a smartphone handy—then if anything does go wrong, you can tell the police who I was with.”

Emma resumed her stroking of his rigid shaft, which felt so good Jonah was unable to bring himself to stop her. She said, “That’s very brave of you, but it does still leave you potentially dead before we know the one you’ve met is the Black Widow. Slight downside to the plan, huh?”

Jonah watched her lean over and gently touch her lips and nose to his cock—not licking him, just being close to his manhood, so that he could feel her hot breath on his flesh. It felt intimate, affectionate somehow.

He tried to reassure her: “We’ll come up with a better plan, I’m sure.”

“And in the mean time, you’re going on a second date with a woman weird enough to be a serial killer?”

“I don’t know if you’d call her weird, she’s just different. And a killer... well, I’m not sure.”

Emma pouted: “I’m not sure this is all about the investigation, is it? You’re basically just going on this one because you’re totally into her kinky sex, right?”

Jonah felt himself blush.

“You liked that she went all dominatrix on you!”

“It was... bizarre...” Jonah said, adding: “That’s all. Just... bizarre.”

He tried to focus on finishing up his shaving, but Emma now grabbed his cock and gave it a harsh squeeze. She said, “You better tell me, Jonah Fielding.”

“Tell you what?”

“What you liked about it. Why you’re going back.”

“It was just... hot. Dangerous. And the way she used me...”

“Yes?”

“I don’t know... it was like there wasn’t so much pressure to perform. Because she was using me, she was doing whatever she wanted with me, it wasn’t up to me to guess what she needed, guess how to make her feel good.”

He could see Emma transfixed to the sight of his cock right there next to her, bobbing and twitching as he thought about what had happened before—kneeling before Jessica, the way she had used him.

“God...” Emma said in quiet awe. “I am going to have to try it out on you.”

She leaned over, and as Jonah was finishing up his shaving, he was a little surprised to suddenly find his shaft enveloped by her searing hot mouth.

“Hey!” he said, pulling himself from her clutches. “You’ll spoil it—you are letting me go on this date, aren’t you?”

She shrugged, and for a moment he thought she might even be pondering whether to support him on this, or not.

“I do want to know what she does next,” she said. “And I want to try it,” she said dreamily, reaching for his cock again, though failing to catch it as he stepped away.

“If you want to know what she does next, we can’t afford to have you set me off ahead of time, right?”

“I suppose.”

“Come on, put your skirt back on—I have to get down to the restaurant.”



“Don’t walk next to me,” he whispered as they neared the restaurant. “What if she sees you?”

“Seriously? She’s using a website to meet men for kinky outdoor sex. You really think she’ll get upset to see you talking with other women?”

Emma had a point, but Jonah was more than a little nervous, prompting him to voice a few too many concerns out loud.

Nevertheless, as they entered the outdoor part of Brown's, his personal assistant did peel off and stride away as though she had nothing to do with him. Jonah groaned—had he annoyed her? He'd never really seen her irritated before, didn't quite know how she dealt with it. Ah well.

It was relatively early in the evening, just after work, so the office crowd were beginning to pour in. Thankfully, though, there were still a few tables available.

Taking a seat, Jonah told himself he couldn't afford to worry about Emma. She had chosen to tag along, to try to get a glimpse of the mysterious Jessica. Getting comfortable, he ordered a beer from the waitress and saw that Emma was seated on her own table on the other side of the outdoor enclosure.

She flashed him a mischievous smile when his eyes found hers, signaling her own impatient excitement at getting to witness this particular woman. She looked perfectly chirpy, and that did actually calm Jonah a little.

Was Jessica actually going to turn up? She'd persuaded a waiter to hand him a message the last time. It meant that this time, Jonah found himself glancing at the waiting staff, as well as keeping his eyes open for Jessica herself while checking his watch every minute or two.

He also kept looking over at Emma, to see if she was still there—and of course she was, though now it seemed a young guy was sitting with her, apparently trying to chat her up. Jonah directed a questioning expression her way, and Emma simply shrugged, appearing to say something like: "What can you do?"

The guys just can't stop hitting on me."

Jonah found himself surprisingly jealous at this interest in his sexy blonde assistant—but stopped himself from dwelling on such a situation. God, how

could he possibly be jealous about Emma, when he was about to meet up with another woman for the expressed purpose of casual sex? And after

all the women he'd been with recently, even if it was intended to shed some light on his brother's murder.

Emma did seem to be playing up the attentions of this other guy, who was about her age but seemed so very young to Jonah with his fresh face and the kind of salon-produced messy hairstyle that seemed the trend for that generation.

Jonah was completely surprised by the hand on his shoulder.

It came from the wrong direction—and Emma was too distracted by her new admirer to offer any kind of warning.

“Robert, isn't it?”

Jonah looked up, more at the sudden contact than the sound of his stage name, since he still didn't quite have that natural response to the sound of it. Mid-thirties, perhaps, average height, brown hair shaved to hide his thinning thatch: it was the same waiter as before, the one who had handed over the shot glass and the message to meet Jessica in the parking garage.

“Yes, that's me,” he said, but the waiter didn't look as though he was waiting for an answer to provide Jonah with another shot glass and a white envelope.

“This is for you.”

The waiter was gone as soon as Jonah had picked up the envelope, but in that moment he'd looked in the man's face, Jonah had registered a strange glint in his eye that suggested perhaps he had an idea what was going on here. Was he even a member of staff here? There were so many waiters in this huge bar-restaurant, it would have been quite easy for someone to slip in, wearing the right color polo shirt. Had his shirt even displayed the logo of the Brown's restaurant chain?

Jonah couldn't be sure.

Emma was now staring across at him, ignoring the poor guy next to her who'd been trying to get into her panties.

Her expression posed a question—was that the same waiter from before? Jonah had forgotten the level of detail he had provided to her when he

gave into her

questions about Jessica. He had told her that a waiter had delivered the message that time.

Jonah gave her a nod, and Emma returned it as though she'd figured everything out already. Then she flashed him a glare, her eyes flicking to the envelope in his hands, urging him to open it.

The envelope was blank other than a three-digit number written in ballpoint pen: 343. Inside, he found a credit-card size plastic card branded clearly with the logo of the Marriott Hotels chain.

A room key, then.

There was no way it could be anywhere other than the Marriott Hotel located just yards away, at Number One West India Quay. The hotel that shared the building with his brother's own apartment.

Jessica would no doubt be waiting in room 343.

Jonah stood, his heart pounding, throat dry. He noticed that Emma had also pulled herself up to her feet, and as he now negotiated his way through the tables toward the exit, she did likewise.

"Where does she want you?" she whispered as we happened to leave the restaurant at the same time.

"The hotel. The one over there, I presume. Room 343."

He caught a very quick glimpse of Emma, which told him all he needed to know

—she appreciated that if the waiter guy was still around, monitoring the situation, reporting back to Jessica, things could sour one way or the other.

Heading out of the restaurant enclosure, Jonah turned left toward the Marriott, but Emma peeled off to the right, making it look as though she had nothing to do with him and never had. She could almost have been a spy, Jonah thought, before deciding she'd probably be more like a Bond girl than a real secret agent.

Walking over to the hotel, Jonah flicked his eyes this way and that, but couldn't see any sign of the waiter.

He entered the building and walked through reception to the elevators, before taking one up to the third floor.

So anxious. Was he being naive to simply discount Jessica's potential to be the Black Widow? Just because it had been a thrill to kneel before the beautiful blonde woman and sample her pussy?

His heart seemed to be in his throat as the elevator stopped on the third floor, and he proceeded down the corridor following the signs to rooms 340-380.

There was the room.

He slotted the plastic card in the slot above the door handle, and caught his breath as the door handle actually turned.



It was a surprise to find the room empty. It wasn't the biggest place in the world

—not even a suite—though the fittings were nice enough. The door to the en suite bathroom was located just around the corner from the small hallway in which the fitted wardrobe was located, and as he rounded into the main space of the room, dominated by the king-sized bed, he saw that the bathroom door was closed. Through it, he could hear the sound of a shower running.

Was she in the bathroom, having a shower?

There was another white envelope on the bed, where he couldn't possibly have missed it, with the name "Robert" printed on the address panel, in the same ballpoint ink as before.

He retrieved the small piece of notepaper, which gave simple instructions: Take off your clothes, lie on the bed on your back. Then you may not move unless permitted.

Jonah felt his loins tingling, butterflies fluttering inside his stomach. What was she planning this time?

A hundred questions swirled around his head as he yanked off his shoes, almost ripped off his shirt, pulled his underwear down with his pants all in one go, so impatient to see Jessica again.

He knew the urgency he felt to see her again was related to the fact that she'd controlled and limited his access so much the time before. Emma was right—

there was something about her treatment that had definitely clicked with him: the dominant woman was certainly a turn-on. After the incredible night he'd had with Lily, maybe it was just a sign that he had a thing for powerful women.

This whole process seemed to be more than just a hunt for a killer—Jonah was discovering more about himself than he ever thought possible.

His nerves were jangling as he sprawled across the bed, and obediently lay on his back, settling into a comfortable position before complying with the final part of the message, remaining still. For a few moments, he just stared up at the ceiling and concentrated on breathing.

The sound of the shower ceased. Jonah's heart started beating heavily, thumping in his chest as though trying to call out to Jessica. He waited, wondering how long she would need to prepare herself after her shower.

It seemed to take so very long. Listening to the sound of a hairdryer in the bathroom, he found his mind wandering, flashing through aspects of his investigation—going through the few clues they knew about the killer, knowing they all pointed to Jessica if he allowed himself to think that way. He had to be careful, he knew that.

Maybe Emma had a point when she said it was all very well planning on her getting a look at Jonah's dates when he met them, but facing death just so that a single person could suggest who was most likely the culprit was a high price to pay just to get a witness.

And what if Emma didn't get a look at her at all? Jessica's strategy was making that possibility difficult.

He hoped Emma was being clever, and perhaps staking out the hotel, or even this room since he'd told her the room number. Perhaps she'd get a glance at Jessica, assuming the same thing happened as last time, and the woman took off as soon as she'd had her fill of him.

The door to the bathroom opened quite suddenly, and Jonah felt his heart perform a little pirouette.

There she was.

He did well just to keep his blood pumping around his body as she paused in the doorway, allowing him to run his eyes over her sensational figure and the elegant yet sexy lingerie she was wearing—black bra with white lace trim, black lace-top stockings with suspenders leading up to a suspender belt, little matching black lacy panties.

Her long, golden hair was down this time, slightly tousled and wavy as it flowed either side of her face, almost as though she'd already had sex that evening.

Once again she wore bright red—hooker red—lipstick, though the rest of her makeup was more subtle.

“Hello again,” she said, her eyes trailing over his body as he lay there, completely exposed to her.

“Hi,” he said, wondering if he was allowed to speak, a warmth now blossoming inside his chest as he saw her eyes dwell on his thickening cock. Did she like what she saw? It seemed so. She gave a slight nod, appreciative.

Calmly, without any rush whatsoever, she walked over to the nearest wardrobe, allowing him a magnificent view of her shapely behind as she did so. He watched her open the wardrobe to retrieve something that Jonah could not quite see until she'd closed the wardrobe again and turned to face him.

A rope—white, not too thick but thick enough that he knew he'd never be able to break it.

Jessica returned to the bed, offering him an encouraging smile that stirred his insides. She had to be as turned on as he was—she'd designed this whole scene, after all. He could see her beautifully flat stomach quivering slightly—did she have butterflies too? Nevertheless, she was good at projecting calm self-assuredness, which you no doubt needed to be the dominant one in this kind of affair.

She climbed onto the bed, and he caught a burst of her exotic perfume as she moved to him, kneeling up with the rope in her hands.

“Are you ready to please me?” she asked, and it seemed to Jonah that she was quite well spoken. Educated, certainly, and no doubt fairly affluent, though not to the extreme.

“Yes, Miss,” he said, not really knowing how to address her, so taking the title he'd last used for female teachers back in school.

She didn't seem to object to it. She said, “Arms up.”

For a brief flash, he had no idea what she meant. It was really his subconscious that responded to her order, raising his arms and meekly holding his wrists together as though she was guiding them by telepathy.

He saw her gently bite on her bottom lip as she curled the rope around his wrists, loop after loop, and there was another burst of heat inside his chest in response.

She wanted him. This stunning woman wanted to use him for her own sexual

gratification.

She'd clearly practiced a little rope work before—her handiwork was excellent.

His wrists were tightly bound with a neat array of turns of the rope, so that it almost appeared to be simply some kind of wristband. Well, this was okay, Jonah thought. He still had his legs free.

Satisfied he was sufficiently bound, Jessica now stood up over him.

What a wondrous sight—Jonah held his breath as he gaped up at her trim body, yet while his eyes couldn't help taking in the hint of her pussy through the semi-transparent panties, her toned belly and her small, pert breasts contained within her bra, it was her blazing eyes that really captured his gaze, locking his focus in place as she now sank slowly down, down, down, knees parting and dropping either side of his head so that her lace-covered sex was mere inches from his face.

She paused briefly, teasing him or perhaps even herself, allowing him a tantalizing glimpse of her pink folds through the luxurious lace and a chestful of her perfume and lingering traces of her grooming products.

Then she was pressing herself down on him, her warm flesh all around his head

—thighs against his cheeks, pussy touching down over his mouth and chin, the rough lace tickling his nose a little as it brushed against it. The heat of her body was astounding.

He could detect the growing scent of her arousal, and it thrilled him. He opened his mouth to kiss her, to taste her, but the way she was almost smothering him, there was little he could do.

Jessica wiggled her hips, jostling him, getting him just where she needed him, wedged over his mouth and nose.

“You like that?” he heard her say, but could only moan his approval in return.

Her hands closed around the top of his head, holding him as she began to gently grind herself on his face, and Jonah had to fight for breath, each precious inhalation increasingly saturated with that glorious female spice.

Time seemed to slow as she pleased herself on his mouth, her moisture

beginning to seep through her panties so that he could taste the same salty tang he remembered from before. He loved her flavor, and the sight of her from this angle was incredible—but what drove him even more was the sound of her deep breathing and quiet moans, signifying her own sexual pleasure, which seemed so much more important than his own.

It was a touch frustrating that his wrists were bound, palms together, in such a way that even though they were tied in front of his chest, he just couldn't bend his elbows in such a way as to be able to touch his hard throbbing cock as she rode his face.

She stood up, and he saw that her cheeks were flushed. She was smiling broadly, and he felt wonderful warmth inside that she was letting go, loosening up a little compared to their first run-in. Then down came her lace panties, and watching her step out of them, Jonah was licking his lips.

When she knelt over him again, giving him a close-up view of her sweet pink pussy, embellished by her little rectangular strip of golden hair above, he felt a deep hunger for her.

"You want this?" she asked him.

"Please, Miss," he said. "More than anything."

She smiled. "I was right to choose you, Robert."

Then she dropped again, but this time did not completely smother him—she held above him just sufficiently to give him free rein to lick her, to suck her tender folds, to push his tongue inside her and nuzzle his nose against her clit.

She tasted divine, and seemed happy for him to perform as he wished, gyrating her hips only a little as he tended to her and lapped up her come. She turned, offering him a taste of her pussy from behind, and the superlative view of her shapely ass, as she continued to ride him, though now facing his feet.

More than anything, Jonah appreciated the time she allowed him on this second occasion. Like being able to appreciate a fine wine, rather than gulp it down. He could dwell on her exquisite bouquet, and savor her complex yet balanced feminine flavor.

He was so focused on experiencing her, he almost failed to notice her hands now moving to his cock, her fingers curling around his shaft, exploring his size and his hardness, taking in the heat of his blood being pumped around its full length.

Yet as she now forced herself down on his face, ending his long leisurely tasting experience in order to use him once more for her own purposes, Jonah felt her squeezing his hardness, and begin a slow but accelerated pumping that he feared could result in a sticky situation developing.

He felt the conflict of his own biological need versus the pressure to please her

—loving the sensation of her body draped all over him, her hand stirring his manhood, her sex wedged against his mouth—and yet while he wanted to hold on to enjoy the moment, the urge to simply let go and explode, release himself as he'd been unable to do before—he could hardly control it.

Her own body now clamped around his head so firmly that he couldn't tell quite what was happening, or whether she was close to her own orgasm. He was confined in a delicious enclosure of her sex, and though he could feel her moving against him, kneading his face with her pussy, he could not hear or really see whether she was nearing her climax.

But she kept pumping him, reaching a furious pace, and there was no way he could stop her.

He felt that twinge just as the point of no return was reached, and then his hot seed was erupting from his manhood, spurting out to land on his belly, Jessica continuing to pump him even after the last drop was spent.

Only then, with his own reserves depleted, did he feel her suddenly step up the pace of her rocking on his face, and she was trembling all around him, a fresh burst of her come seeping from her quivering pussy as he lapped at her flushed lips.



There was a moment, afterwards, where she simply lay on him, and Jonah felt so calm and wonderfully satiated that he was happy to have her there, her inner thighs still either side of his head, her sex so explicit right there in his face.

He felt an enormous sense of gratitude that she'd allowed him release, he was quite happy to wait there until she was ready to extricate herself from him.

So comfortable and warm, the endorphins flowing around his system like opium, granting a cozy sense of serenity. He even found his eyelids growing heavy, and allowed himself to close them, feeling sure there could be no harm in catching a moment or two of rest.

Nine

He was woken with a jolt by a furious banging on the door.

“Jonah!” he heard Emma’s voice, muted a little by the door keeping her out.

“Jonah!”

Jonah rubbed his eyes, his vision swimming a little, his balance not quite there.

What had happened? He’d fallen asleep. Jesus—what an idiot?

Briefly, he took in the scene—the room was completely empty other than him, perfectly neat and tidy with absolutely no sign of Jessica. She must have gone—

Emma must have seen her go, else she wouldn’t be hammering at the door.

But his young blonde friend’s continuing hammering against the door forced him up, yelling out a quick: “I’m here, I’m okay!” as he scampered to the door to let her in.

Noticing that Jessica had untied him, taking her rope with her when she’d gone.

“Oh God—I thought you were a goner,” Emma said breathlessly, rushing through the door and jumping on him, hugging him furiously. “I saw her leave, and then you weren’t answering your phone, and when I got here, you weren’t answering the door...”

She was pale, afraid. He'd never seen her like this before.

"I'm sorry," he said. "I fell asleep."

"Oh, must have been good, then," her wisecrack brought back the Emma he knew, but Jonah felt sorry to have given her such a scare.

"I was just so spent—I closed my eyes for a moment afterwards, and when I opened them again, you were beating the door down—"

"—and she was gone," Emma finished for him. "Charming—doesn't she even

wait to say goodbye?"

She reached up and kissed his mouth, and Jonah wasn't even thinking as he brought his hands to her soft face and kissed her back, tasting the sweetness of her mouth and the lingering trace of -

"I can taste her," Emma said as they broke apart, her eyes wide, her face filled with light as she realized what it was that was making his kiss so different to the last time she'd kissed his mouth.

She clamped her hands around the back of his head and now pulled him to her for another deep kiss—sampling Jessica's personal flavor secondhand. Jonah wondered if there were any real boundaries to this girl's sexuality.

He felt things stirring down below as her tongue slipped inside his mouth, her hands gripping his hips, the thought of this pretty little blonde so curious about the powerfully beautiful Jessica really sparked something inside him. How stunning would it be to witness the two of them together?

"I saw her leaving the hotel," Emma said, kicking the door of the room shut behind her. "She was unbelievable. So beautiful."

She pushed him back, and he allowed her to coax him over towards the bed, where she shoved him onto the edge of the mattress, his cock thickening as he saw her reach under her little black skirt to slip aside her underwear before climbing onto his lap, her hot, bare little pussy touching down on his cock as it attained full rigidity.

He warned her: “I’m not sure how much energy I have left.”

But she shook her head, touched a forefinger to his lips, said, “Shh. I just want to kiss you, I want to imagine her having her wicked way with you.”

And then he was inside her, her tight pussy squeezing him delightfully, her agile hips gyrating sensually as she pumped him, pushing him back on the bed so she could explore his mouth with hers.

“You want to know something really interesting?” she said just before the final push to orgasm.

“What’s that?”

“When I saw her leave the hotel, she was walking hand in hand with that waiter guy from the restaurant.”

“You think they’re an item?”

“Kinky, huh. Like Lily and her husband, maybe.”



They enjoyed the hotel room the rest of the night—it was paid for, whether Jessica and her partner wanted it or not, and neither Emma nor Jonah felt the need to vacate the room merely to find another bed in which to sleep.

Emma was still sleeping as he slipped out of bed and threw on his clothes. He was making a habit of the quiet exit, but the pretty blonde seemed so peaceful, and needed her rest after the previous night.

Jonah had things to do. Nate’s apartment was on the market now, it wouldn’t take long to shift according to the agent. He had plenty of packing to do in the meantime.

He decided to wait until his return to the apartment for a shower, since he didn’t want to wake Emma prematurely. But after leaving the hotel and circling the building in the low light of the dawn, he found a familiar

vehicle parked out in front of the residential side of the complex, and regretted his decision.

The driver door opened to reveal the increasingly familiar form of Detective Inspector Mulray.

“Detective,” he said.

“Mr Fielding,” she greeted him with a polite shake of the hand. “Coming home at this hour of the morning?”

“Oh, you know how it is. Things to do, people to see.”

As ever, she looked stunning. Another dark suit attempting to play down her curves, makeup subtly applied to minimize attention, mocha hair pulled back to emphasize professionalism.

“You’re still making good use of that website, then?” There was an edge to her voice—she did not approve. Yet she wasn’t coming straight out and telling him.

Not her job, he guessed.

“Haven’t looked at it for a while, actually,” he said, technically speaking a little truth, since Emma had largely taken on the job of managing the website stuff.

She knew far better than he did how a guy like Nate would chat up the right kind

of women through that website, after all.

Mulray gave a slight nod of the head—approval, perhaps, though in those large, intelligent eyes what Jonah saw was more like contemplation of his white lie.

She was always trying to work him out, and this time was no different. She thought him more mysterious, more interesting than he really was, but with his crush, he wasn’t going to try to persuade her otherwise.

“I wanted to talk to you about it,” she said now.

“Should I be expecting a visit from some of your senior detective friends?”

She leaned back against the car, and he could see the disappointment even in the flicker of a hesitation before she said, “They’re not exactly in a rush.”

Jonah nodded. He felt a heavy stone drop inside his stomach, and curiously it didn’t seem to him that it was anything to do with the police deciding not to take his suggestion about the website seriously. He felt the gloom stealing over him from the thought that a certain brunette detective might not see him any more since he had no more leads to offer in the case.

“They say why?” he asked her.

“You want to take this inside? There’s... well, a chill in the air.”

Jonah didn’t feel particularly cold, but the way her eyes darted this way and that, it didn’t seem to be the temperature she was worried about. Did she know something? Was he under surveillance after all? Did they think he was a suspect?

Were the police not after a woman?

“Sure,” he said, as though accepting her reasoning without question. “If you don’t mind watching me packing up my brother’s stuff.”

“No problem,” the detective said.

Jonah added: “I’m going to need to take a quick shower before anything.”

“Of course,” she said.

“You can wait in my kitchen if you like.”

She gave him another look at that, but he caught a gentle blush in her cheeks at the acknowledgement that last time she’d been in his apartment, she’d watched him taking a shower through the semi-transparent shower room wall. God knew why Nate had had that installed.

As they passed the bored concierge, and entered the elevator, Mulray changed the subject. “Never seems to be many people coming or going in this building,”

she said. “Other than you and your guests.”

Jonah shrugged, he’d noticed how empty the place usually seemed, of course.

“Half of the apartments—at least—are just investments,” he explained. “Bought up by the Chinese or Russian oligarchs or the oil sheikhs. Hardly anyone really lives here.”

Mulray nodded.

He added, “Our concierge must have the most tedious job in London.”

“Him and all the other guys in luxury apartment blocks, huh.”

“Nate always liked the privacy.”

Inside the little steel and glass box, Jonah attempted to keep as much distance from the detective as possible without making it seem obvious, leaning back against the wall as they climbed, butt wedged against the steel rail.

“I wanted to ask you something about him,” she said. “Might seem a little...

insensitive.”

“Fire away.”

“Did your brother ever... pay for sex?”

Jonah scratched his head, realizing his hair was in a somewhat crazy state. He said, “Other than his membership fee for that website—but I’m not sure if you’d define that as—”

“What I mean is,” she cut in, “would he ever use the services of a prostitute?”

Jonah felt a little jolt burst in his chest. He remembered that Guardian journalist,

Keeley, suggesting that the police were looking into connections to prostitution.

Was this what Mulray was getting at? Suddenly he felt his confidence in his lost brother shaken—her question alone offered enough of a suggestion that she knew something about Nate that Jonah didn't.

He said, "No—I don't think he ever needed to."

Mulray nodded. He felt her eyes on him, examining his face to assess his reliability as a witness. Jonah hugged himself, as though it would keep the subtle scent of sex to himself until he could hit the shower.

He said, "When he was with his mates in the City, they were the kind of guys who'd probably drag him to some strip club or other once in a while. I doubt he'd ever—"

"He wouldn't ever get a kick out of paying for it?"

Jonah shook his head. "I can't see it."

He hesitated as the elevator came to a halt and the doors opened, despite the likelihood there would be no one lurking in the hallway out there.

"Your boss said in the press conference that Martin Sallow hired prostitutes," he said. "Now you're asking me about my brother. So your colleagues are linking the murders?"

She nodded. "And, would you believe it, they're ready to consider Julian Foster as being part of it."

"Julian Foster, using prostitutes? You talk to Lily about all this?"

"Not particularly happy at the idea, as you could imagine."

Jonah remembered the photograph of Julian Foster that had been dropped in the wastepaper basket. Julian's grieving widow must have been in two minds about the grieving part, since he'd effectively been cheating on her the last few months, or even years, before his death. If he had started

paying for sex, it was probably not something he'd tell his wife about, despite what they'd done together before the kid came along. So she wouldn't have been able to say anything about it to Jonah.

He tapped out the code, and as the door clicked open, he said, "So why the rethink over Julian Foster? Is it because I got you his log-in details for that website?"

"Not so much the website."

Disappointment throbbed inside him. "They did look at that?"

She sighed. "They looked at it. Told me they didn't find any evidence of recent dating."

Jonah offered her a seat on one of the white couches, but as they ventured into the apartment, he noticed that for just a flash, Mulray's eyes were involuntarily drawn to the transparent wall showing through to the darkened bathroom. Was she remembering watching him? Jonah concealed a smile—he bet there was a fiery, passionate young woman under her carefully controlled exterior.

"But he had an account? His history probably got deleted after a certain amount of time."

"He had an account. I don't know about his history. My colleagues took the fact that he had an account as supporting the idea he could have consorted with prostitutes."

"But that wasn't what got them interested in linking Julian to the other murders?"

The DI shook her head, "That was more from what Lily told me."

"She spoke to you about... the other night?"

"She was a lot more open than she's been before."

"She told you everything that happened?" Jonah found himself blushing. He started examining the boxes of Nate's belongings that were piled up behind the couch, as though to distract from the embarrassment.

Mulray laughed. “Well, maybe not everything. But she told me about... you know, the swinging.”

“I think they call it ‘The Lifestyle’ now,” Jonah said. “Or something like that.”

“I heard that. Lily was much more open about the whole thing. I guess you really made an impression on her. She couldn’t stop talking about you.”

He felt himself flush again.

“She’s good fun,” Jonah said, trying to play it down in front of the girl he had a burning crush on. “So are you going to pass on all the details about her to your colleagues?”

The detective said, “I’ve passed on her suspicions that her husband was using that particular website of yours. And I guess it’s flagged up the possibility that he is linked to this prostitution angle. But what happened before her kid came along... well, I don’t see that it’s relevant just now.”

“And the fact that I happened to meet Lily?”

“I’ll report back any useful facts that are exposed, but I don’t see that my colleagues need to know everything about your day-to-day lives.”

There were so many boxes lying around half-filled with Nate’s belongings, casting his eye over them quite depressed Jonah. There was still a lot to be done.

Ordinarily in a house sale, he might have a few months to deal with it all, but if the real estate agent was talking about foreign investors snapping this place up, he might not have quite so long. The trouble was, packing was so dull, it took him ages.

“Are your colleagues done with Julian’s account, then? On that website?”

Mulray gave him another look, a silent warning. Almost a threat.

“Look, if they’re not going to give any credence to it—” he said.

She sighed. “Just don’t be obvious about it. Don’t use your computer—”

“I don’t have one.”

“Don’t use your little blonde friend’s computer then, or that Internet cafe you like so much in Tottenham Court Road.”

He nodded. Trying not to be too creeped out about the disturbing amount of information she had on his movements. Checking the contents of one of his half-filled boxes—books, mostly. He still had half of Nate’s bookshelves to empty—

he got the feeling that Mulray had something else to tell him, perhaps what she’d meant to tell him all along.

“Is there anything else?” he asked her. “I do have to try and get through some of this damn packing today.”

She nodded. “We’ve got a suspect in custody.”

“A suspect?”

“There’s another press conference happening tonight to reveal the details. I thought you ought to know ahead of time.”

How did such news come as a disappointment to Jonah? Did he feel all his efforts had been in vain? Surely he should be pleased the police had someone in custody for his brother’s murder.

“She knew Nate?”

“Possibly. She certainly knew Martin Sallow. Witnesses say someone like him picked her up the night he was killed.”

Jonah felt faintly stunned. Did he know Nate as well as he thought he did? If Nate had been using prostitutes, would it have been something he’d have told his brother? Not necessarily, he had to suspect. Nate hadn’t said anything about sleeping with married women, so could prostitution really be off the table?

“Who is she? The suspect.”

“Someone popular among City traders, supposedly. But she might have had something of a grudge, too. Bank repossessed her home, then soon

after that she lost her kid...”

“Sounds like a perfect patsy.”

“I’m only telling you what I’ve been told.”

“And presumably nothing links this suspect to Lord Moss?”

“You’re still pushing that angle?” she said, a trifle exasperated. “Be satisfied, we now think it’s a serial killer. None of us know what happened to Lord Moss, let’s move on.”

“By which you mean trust that you’ve got the right woman?”

“We’ll see. Now, you going to take that shower, Mr Fielding? Because I don’t have all the time in the world here, and if I don’t get my little show, I’m going to be frustrated all day.”

Jonah laughed, but his stomach suddenly sparked into flames at her suggested interest in him. “Well, you are the law, so I guess I’d better obey.”



He thought she’d be gone when he was done with his shower, but when Jonah padded out of the bathroom, a white towel wrapped around his waist, he found her standing in the living room area of the apartment, phone pressed against her ear, watching Nate’s large television, which, as usual, featured the rolling news channel BBC News 24.

From the sound of it, the item being broadcast was about school exam results—

the nation’s “A”-Level results were out, and as happened every year, the results were getting better, prompting questions about exam questions getting easier.

“...a growing proportion of students passing their exams doesn’t always mean the exams are easier, it could be that they’re simply better prepared...”

What was she watching?

From the chest of drawers in the bedroom area of the open-plan apartment, Jonah grabbed a t-shirt and a pair of sweatpants, and a couple of blinks later stepped in beside Mulray.

“I’m with him now,” she was saying to whoever it was on the phone.
“No, he didn’t believe the prostitute story either.”

Jonah gave her a quizzical look, not that he expected her to open up about who was on the phone, what she was doing monitoring trivial news stories.

“Any minute?” she asked the person on the other end of the line.

Then she turned to Jonah, and cocked her head in the direction of the television screen, urging him to watch it.

The report on exam grades came to a premature end, as the familiar deep dramatic tones of the BBC News 24 theme music kicked in, alongside the revolving globe graphics that then displayed the titles: “Breaking News”.

“We have breaking news that’s just come in the last minute,” said the presenter, Anna Ford. “Police have confirmed that a body has been found in the last hour at the London hotel Claridges. Although few details have been released, detectives have described the killing as suspicious, with sources inside Scotland Yard

suggesting that the death is being linked to a series of murders at London hotels during the course of the last year...”

Mulray had hung up on whichever colleague it was with whom she’d been talking.

Referring to the TV report, he asked her: “Your suspect?”

Mulray shook her head. “She was safely locked up when it happened.”

“And now?”

“They’ve released her without charge. I would think my colleagues must be redirecting the investigation, at the very least.”

“Good.”

“Means I’ve got to get back, I’m afraid.”

“Of course. Well, thanks for updating me on the investigation, for what it was worth.”

She nodded. “Remember: don’t go in Julian Foster’s account unless you can do it without leaving a trace.”

“No. I’ll make sure.”



Jonah felt a low throb of pain in his stomach as the detective finally left, like mild food poisoning. Another murder. So soon after the last one.

It was doubly hard to concentrate on the packing. Slumped by the bookshelves in the bedroom, he had resorted to sweeping armfuls of books into his current box.

He felt so drained.

He heard the front door key code being entered, the shrill tones cutting through the apartment even above the low noise of the television and its continuing news coverage. Surprised, though hardly feeling he had the energy to deal with an intruder, he looked up to see the door open and Emma breeze into the apartment.

“You know, those door codes are supposed to be secret?” he said, though he was pleased to see her.

“Then don’t keep typing it into the keypad out there so other people can see,”

she replied, drifting through into the bedroom, beautiful, fresh, showered. “You see the news?”

“Of course. Mulray said they had a suspect in custody, but this has just blown all that out of the water.”

“Where does it leave us and the website?” Emma pitched forward onto the bed, so that she lay with her head over the edge of the mattress, from where she could just about reach Jonah for a kiss.

“I think it backs up our theory, if anything,” he said.

One more sweep of the arm, in the laziest approach to packing there was, and Jonah suddenly stopped, frozen, staring at the box in which he had been dumping books. There, under a couple of Dennis Lehane thrillers, was a book he’d seen very recently in the home of Julian Foster.

‘The Watchers’ by Alex Higson.

A Killer of a One Night Stand In the Next Episode...

After another body is discovered, the police have finally accepted they are hunting a serial killer. Jonah investigates an important clue that could link his brother Nate to the first victim, Julian Foster. Has Lily been lying to him?

He finds himself going deeper into the world of wife-sharing and unconventional marital relationships. Was this what Nate was involved in? Did he get involved with a couple where the feelings were so strong it might have led to murder?

Meanwhile, an unlikely ally reveals important clues in the case of Lord Moss’s murder.

Episode Three: Available now at all good e-bookstores web:
MaxSebastian.net/a-killer-of-a-one-night-stand/



more hot wives
exploring other men...

4 free erotic stories
when you join the mailing list at:
maxsebastian.net/free

Document Outline

- [Cover Page](#)
- [Cover](#)
- [About the Author](#)
- [Some of Max's Other Books](#)
- [Title Page](#)
- [Copyright](#)
- [Contents](#)
- [Prologue](#)
- [Chapter 1](#)
- [Chapter 2](#)
- [Chapter 3](#)
- [Chapter 4](#)
- [Chapter 5](#)
- [Chapter 6](#)
- [Chapter 7](#)
- [Chapter 8](#)
- [Chapter 9](#)
- [A Killer of a One Night Stand](#)
- [Full Page Image](#)

目录

Cover Page	1
Cover	2
About the Author	3
Some of Max's Other Books	3
Title Page	4
Copyright	4
Contents	4
Prologue	5
Chapter 1	10
Chapter 2	28
Chapter 3	32
Chapter 4	44
Chapter 5	55
Chapter 6	78
Chapter 7	88
Chapter 8	98
Chapter 9	113
A Killer of a One Night Stand	126
Full Page Image	127